POWER / FREEDOM / RESENTMENT / AI

We Manufacture Our Own Masters



Communism. Capitalism.
Elites. Dependence.
The struggle to remain free.

The Antinomies of Governance and the Refusal of Domination

ENGLISH EDITION · SEPTEMBER 2026

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The Starting Point: The Questions I Asked

This opening restates the author's original Romanian brief in English, retaining its first-person perspective and its substantive doubts. Personal recollections remain recollections; suspicions remain questions to be tested. The argument and its supporting literature follow after the contents.

I want to write a book that tries to establish—and, at the same time, dismantle—a series of antinomies about our political positions, the mechanisms of government, and the ways societies organise themselves. I want the initial ideas extended, not politely replaced. Where similar contradictions exist in other domains, they should be brought into the discussion.

My starting impression is that there may be something like a curse of antinomies, borrowing the word from Kant's *Critique of Pure Reason*. We pursue equality and recreate a nobility. We defend economic freedom and build organisations that command people's lives. We multiply the means of expression and destroy the conditions for listening. We entrust decisions to the competent and produce a caste. We decentralise power and discover that defending decentralisation requires concentrating force again.

These are not merely the familiar observation that nothing is perfect. The more disturbing possibility is that the mechanism through which an ideal succeeds can help produce its opposite. I want to know how much of that possibility survives serious scrutiny. Is there a way out, or will civilisation always be walking on eggshells?

1. Equality can conceal a new nobility

On one side, I find it difficult not to want a fair society: egalitarian, or at least approximately egalitarian. Yet I suspect that the attempt can end in false equality and the creation of hidden social classes. Here my starting point is personal experience of communism, not nostalgia for a theory I have never had to live under.

There was a levelling of economic circumstances. But the party nomenklatura, the secret services, and the police could exercise discretionary, undeserved, and abusive power over the majority. The nobility had, in effect, reinvented itself. It did not need an inherited title or a publicly spectacular fortune. Position, access, protection, and the ability to decide another person's future were enough.

The same order could drain the motivation of capable people. Specialists were expected to function as tools of politics. Some found refuge in science, especially technical and mathematical disciplines, where an answer could not always be replaced by a slogan. Economics and the social sciences were more dangerous terrain: thinking independently about society could mean challenging the people who claimed to embody it.

My impression is of a wider degeneration. Social and economic decisions became increasingly detached from reality, contributing to poverty, emotional violence, cultural coarsening, and damage to spiritual and cultural life. That is a subjective assessment rooted in experience; the book should identify what the historical evidence supports rather than turn my biography into a universal dataset.

There were undoubtedly achievements and perhaps forms of cooperation that were activated more effectively than under capitalism. In my own assessment, they do not come close to cancelling the damage. Nevertheless, they should be examined. Were people cooperating because the system cultivated solidarity, because they had to protect one another against it, or both?

The dilemma is not simply whether equality is good. It is whether the power needed to impose an extensive equality becomes an inequality more invasive than the one it removes. Who equalises the equaliser? And what becomes of excellence when the excellent must remain politically subordinate to people selected for other reasons?

2. Capitalism can reproduce structures that feel disturbingly familiar

On the other side, I do not find capitalism innocent merely because communism was worse. Even films about American teenagers and the relationships between rich and poor can make the social mechanisms visible: access, humiliation, status, inherited confidence, and the informal boundaries of belonging. Films are not statistical evidence. They are one of the things that prompted the question.

Some corporations look, from the inside, like reduced versions of the societies I thought we had left behind. There are official narratives, rituals of agreement, internal hierarchies, rewards for loyalty, and risks attached to saying something inconvenient. The comparison is not that an employment contract and a totalitarian state are identical. It is that formally different systems may cultivate recognisably similar forms of dependence and conformity.

Public discourse can also display a drift towards what I can only call an idiocracy: simplified slogans, performative certainty, hostility to complexity, and the replacement of thought by belonging. Through the lens of someone formed by communism, aspects of contemporary capitalism can look less like an absolute opposite than a distorted mirror.

At the same time, liberal capitalist democracies plainly offer more grounds for hope to a young person—and to capable people more generally—that sustained effort can lead somewhere. The book should acknowledge this advantage without converting it into a blanket defence of the order that provides it. A system can offer real mobility and still systematically protect inherited advantage. Both things can be true.

The question is therefore sharper than which system is less bad. Does the freedom to accumulate eventually buy the power to close opportunities to others? Does competition generate winners who then remove the conditions of competition? Can liberal capitalism renew itself without relying on a crisis severe enough to endanger liberalism itself?

3. Freedom of speech can coexist with the suppression of attention

Censorship need not be organised through a single official institution. Without adopting a conspiracy theory, we can ask how much independence a press has when its ownership and financing are concentrated among economic elites. An elite's wish to preserve its position is intelligible. Influencing what other people consider normal, desirable, respectable, or possible can be part of preserving that position.

There is also censorship through noise. In the name of freedom of expression, a system can amplify nonsense and drown out what is inconvenient. This can be done strategically, especially by actors who control distribution algorithms. It can also emerge without a central plan from competition for attention and revenue. The distinction matters, but neither possibility is reassuring.

There have always been more people willing to speak than people willing to listen carefully and think deeply. The internet gives foolishness additional channels through which to validate itself, gather an audience, and multiply its reach. It gives genuine insight channels too. The question is what the dominant incentives select, not whether an intelligent text can theoretically be published somewhere.

The resulting spectacle can resemble a tyranny of the majority, recalling the legitimising language of the rule of the working class. But perhaps it is not really the majority ruling. Perhaps it is a market in reactions, a highly active minority, or the owners of the machinery through which a majority is made visible.

Can a society retain freedom of expression while losing much of its capacity for public thought? If people are technically free to speak but the architecture of attention reliably favours anger, repetition, and stupidity, what exactly has been secured—and what has been lost?

4. Intellectuals and experts can become mandarins

I do not assume that intellectuals would govern us well. Intellectual ability and formal education do not guarantee independence, courage, good judgement, or concern for the public. A bureaucracy of the educated can become a caste of mandarins: people who reproduce the signs of learning more reliably than they produce independent thought.

The comparison with historical Chinese scholar-officials is an analogy about selection, not a complete description of that civilisation. My concern is the difference between memory and thought. Memorised erudition is legible, examinable, and often professionally useful. Independent thinking is more expensive. It takes time, produces awkward intermediate results, and can lead someone into positions that look ridiculous—temporarily, or perhaps permanently.

An organisation that rewards the safe reproduction of approved knowledge may therefore select against the qualities it claims to value. The best performer in an intellectual hierarchy is not necessarily the person who understands the problem best. It may be the person who understands the hierarchy best.

Nor is "what is optimal for society" an innocent expression. Someone chooses the objectives, the trade-offs, and the people whose losses will be considered acceptable. Elites appear almost inevitably in that choice. Yet decisions must be taken. An unlimited plurality of opinions can delay action and may obstruct some forms of progress.

I want that tension analysed rather than dissolved into a slogan about participation. When does pluralism improve correction, and when does it prevent coordination? When is expertise necessary, and when does it become a protected claim to rule? Who has the authority to close a debate—and who can force it open again?

5. No doctrine should be allowed to excuse itself

If the usual systems do not hold together all the way down, why should the Chinese model not be considered? It can appear attractive to those who want to replace or reshape Western liberal democracy. The book should examine its strengths and weaknesses seriously, including performance, continuity, selection, obedience, information, and correction. It should not answer a question about capability with a declaration of moral disapproval.

But the absence of a clean solution is also a dangerous opening. Why not the "Universal Party of God," or some equally extravagant promise of final unity? The name is a deliberately provocative thought experiment, not a proposal to establish such a party. The point is to test the argument: if every existing system is compromised, does that make any alternative equally defensible? Surely not—but the reason must be made explicit.

Institutional capture by clique-like or mafia-like groups, the promotion of values, the selection of leaders, and the maintenance of loyalty must be examined in every form of governance. The relevant story is likely probabilistic and conditional. Different arrangements may expose us to different distributions of failure, even when none provides a guarantee.

The working challenge is that neither libertarianism, nor classical democratic liberalism, nor a form of socialism can claim coherence and stability merely by restating its founding ideal. Each has to explain why the power it creates will not consume the conditions that make it defensible. I do not want one doctrine acquitted simply because another produces a more obvious disaster.

6. Resentment can become the fuel of political domination

If classical communism tends towards impoverishment, liberal capitalism may become sufficiently hypocritical to manufacture enemies within itself. It promises merit and mobility while producing more educated, ambitious people than there are elite positions for them to occupy. Some of the excluded may resent the existing elite not because they reject domination, but because they believe they should be the ones exercising it.

There can be resentment among the middle strata and among poorer strata. My sharper suspicion is that parts of the lower strata may direct hostility not only upwards, but towards the middle class, its culture, and its rules. That is a proposition to investigate, not a statement about an inherent nature shared by all poor people. The book must ask when this hostility appears, what creates it, and who organises it.

Top elites may benefit from playing these groups against one another. Divide and rule does not require an omnipotent planner; it can emerge from repeated, opportunistic bargains. But the people who begin the game do not necessarily remain in control. More extremist and more unscrupulous competitors can take it over, mobilising resentment towards a more authoritarian order and the reduction of civil liberties.

The question is not merely why people become angry. It is why some forms of anger are converted into collective correction while others become a demand for punishment, obedience, and a leader permitted to break every rule. What prevents an opposition to a ruling caste from becoming the recruitment campaign of the next caste?

7. Can freedom erode the human conditions of its own survival?

This is the most uncomfortable part of my initial concern. Liberal democracy seems to require some combination of education, judgement, self-discipline, civic responsibility, and a willingness to accept rules even when they are inconvenient. Yet the conditions it offers may not automatically reproduce those qualities across generations.

People who invest heavily in education, careers, and the enjoyment of an autonomous life may have few children. Other groups may grow faster through religious or cultural commitments to large families, different survival strategies, or less attention to the resources required to raise each child well. My suspicion is that a mismatch could develop between numerical reproduction and the transmission of the capacities needed to sustain a demanding free society.

In its harshest version, this concern asks whether a system can lower its average level of civic competence by making it easier to reproduce without making the investment required to educate, socialise, and prepare children for responsibility. Are rights being discussed without adequate attention to the obligations and institutional conditions that make those rights durable? Could openness protect ways of life that eventually use their numerical strength against openness itself?

I also asked whether differences in cognitive ability, work discipline, education, and fertility might combine with frustration and limited opportunities to create populations especially vulnerable to demagogues. A person who cannot find a credible path to success may be offered a more attractive explanation: an enemy has stolen the life to which they were entitled. Political entrepreneurs can then turn resentment into electoral fuel.

These are the questions as questions, not established biological conclusions. Education, measured cognitive performance, inherited traits, culture, poverty, parenting, and civic behaviour must not be collapsed into a single ranking of human beings. A religious affiliation or a social class does not by itself establish an inherited intellectual capacity. Nor does a difference in a population average determine an individual's abilities or future.

The demand is to investigate the severe version of the worry rather than either endorse it by insinuation or dismiss it without analysis. Which links have evidence? Which depend on a particular place or cohort? Which are contradicted by the data? Which can be changed by education, opportunity, family support, or institutional design? Can a liberal society reproduce the capabilities it needs without turning reproduction itself into an instrument of coercive rule?

8. Local freedom meets organised force

Perhaps cosmolocalism is the most promising remaining direction: global sharing of knowledge combined with more local production, ownership, and decision-making. It might allow us to escape both the centralised state and the concentrated corporation. But localism looks vulnerable to the same forces that threaten liberal democracy more generally.

A local community is not automatically peaceful, rational, tolerant, or competent. Extremist groups can try to impose their will. Predatory groups can try to take resources by force. A community that has decentralised production but cannot defend itself may discover that its practical constitution is whatever an armed outsider permits.

Then defence becomes necessary. Defence invites coordination, taxation, command, and a concentration of coercive capacity. The attempt to preserve local autonomy can produce a central power capable of monopolising violence. This is precisely the loop I want examined: we decentralise to avoid a master, then build an organisation to protect the decentralisation, and that organisation may become the master.

This is also why I am suspicious of the Dark Enlightenment and of proprietary versions of localism associated with some technology elites. Dividing territory into privately managed jurisdictions does not necessarily distribute power among the people who live there. It may merely multiply the number of owners.

Can the monopoly of legitimate force be controlled without being rendered incapable of defence? Can a federation prevent both invasion from outside and tyranny within its members? Who protects the dissident who is trapped not by a large state, but by a small community with no real alternative?

9. AI may abolish scarcity—or make dependence comprehensive

Artificial intelligence may alter the entire arrangement. Will it require a universal basic income and a paternalistic state that is always one political turn away from a corrupt dystopia? Or could it enable much more radical decentralisation, allowing smaller communities and individuals to acquire capabilities previously reserved for large organisations?

The optimistic possibility is not simply more efficient administration. It is a genuine dispersal of productive capacity: knowledge, tools, coordination, and perhaps local manufacturing becoming widely accessible. If the problem of coercive power can also be addressed, this might open a route towards a feasible and benign utopia.

The darker possibility is that most people lose the economic leverage their labour once gave them. They continue to receive what they need, but from institutions that no longer need much from them. A guaranteed income might then function as emancipation, a dividend from shared wealth, or a maintenance allowance paid to a politically dependent population. The amount of the payment does not tell us which of these arrangements we are living in.

Who owns the AI systems, the computing infrastructure, the energy, and the channels of distribution? Who can revoke access? What happens to a citizen who refuses the provider's political demands? The book should examine whether abundance changes the old problem of power—or merely gives it a more comfortable interface.

10. What happens when people no longer have to get up in the morning?

Even material abundance leaves another problem. What motivates people who do not have much imagination, a consuming vocation, or an appetite for long intellectual projects when economic necessity no longer structures their day? Some will explore art, science, the cosmos, or forms of community. What about the much larger number who do not spontaneously become artists or researchers?

How many orgies, bands, games, and virtual worlds can consume the time of billions of people before some grow resentful, bored, or hungry for adventures that feel real? A virtual achievement may satisfy some people. Others may want power that someone else cannot switch off—or the satisfaction of making a real person submit.

Evolution has not left us with only curiosity, tenderness, and cooperation. Status competition, domination, exploitation, cruelty, and the pleasure of victory over others are part of the possibilities that political institutions have to confront. It would be naive to assume that feeding people eliminates those motives. It would also be unjustified to assume that everyone will become destructive when paid employment disappears.

I want the hard question left intact: can a post-work civilisation provide consequential responsibility, credible achievement, belonging, and limits without recreating an economy of humiliation? Can it remain a civilisation of adults rather than a managed entertainment environment whose inhabitants are comfortable only while they agree to stay harmless?

11. The contradiction is the point, not an inconvenience to edit out

The book should extend these questions into other areas where a virtue may undermine itself: tolerance and self-defence; transparency and privacy; safety and initiative; ecological restraint and freedom; moral authority and immunity from criticism. These additions must deepen the argument, not distract from the original chain of dilemmas.

The possibility I want examined is that the usual political ideals are not self-sustaining. They need resources, capabilities, habits, and limits that they may themselves weaken. A society may consume trust faster than it replenishes it, reward the closure of competition, train conformity under the name of competence, and finance dependency while calling it protection.

If there is a way out, it cannot consist of saying that people should be nicer or that institutions should be more transparent. Those may be desirable, but they are not an answer to someone who benefits from opacity and possesses the means to preserve it. Who can resist, with what resources, and against whose opposition?

I do not require the conclusion that no solution exists. That would be another claim needing an argument. Nor do I want hope manufactured to make the ending pleasant.

The task is to discover whether there are arrangements that remain defensible under hostile leadership, corruption, opportunism, demographic change, and technological upheaval—not merely while their founders remain wise.

The Book I Asked For

I asked for a sober, lucid, realistic book. Not a defence of my intuitions at any price, and not their conversion into harmless generalities. The text should preserve the severity of the questions, improve their language, make the causal steps explicit, and confront them with scientific literature wherever relevant literature exists.

The investigation must work in both directions. Construct the strongest coherent version of each antinomy. Then try to break it. Identify a hidden assumption, a distinction that dissolves an apparent contradiction, a counterexample, or an institution that interrupts the destructive loop. A proposition should not become safe from criticism merely because it sounds brutally realistic. Equally, an uncomfortable possibility should not be removed merely because it can be expressed impolitely.

I asked for direct comparison across systems. Communism, liberal capitalism, libertarianism, technocracy, authoritarian developmentalism, cosmolocalism, and proprietary jurisdictions should face the same questions about capture, selection, incentives, information, force, and correction. Their differences matter. They are not interchangeable. But the existence of a worse regime is not an alibi for the domination exercised by a better one.

The text must distinguish what is lived experience, what is an interpretation, what is a theoretical mechanism, what has empirical support, and what remains speculative. Where evidence is missing, say so. Where the evidence contradicts my suspicion, show the contradiction. Do not invent probabilities, claim that every elite secretly coordinates with every other elite, or treat a comparison as proof of identity. A logically possible chain of events is not yet an estimate of how frequently it occurs.

I also asked that the discussion of demographic and cultural reproduction remain present. It should not be replaced by a general paragraph about kindness or inclusion. It must address the reproduction of education, responsibility, competence, and liberal norms, together with the evidential limits of claims about biology, fertility, and group behaviour. The aim is to test a danger, not to turn social groups into permanent biological verdicts.

The final part must take AI seriously as a possible transformation of the distribution of power, not merely as a productivity tool. It must consider ownership, dependence, a guaranteed income, the monopoly of force, post-work motivation, real and virtual achievement, status, and the possibility that comfort will not pacify the desire to dominate.

The title should be firm rather than consoling or fatalistic. *We Manufacture Our Own Masters* names the danger running through the argument. It is not a claim that the

dominated are equally responsible for their domination, or that coercion is secretly voluntary. It identifies a question: how do institutions created to protect, liberate, educate, or coordinate us become mechanisms through which some acquire durable power over others?

The requested destination is therefore not a reassuring constitution sketched in the final chapter. It is an honest answer to whether the loops can be interrupted, at what cost, and for how long. If the strongest conclusion is conditional rather than final, it should remain conditional. What must disappear is not uncertainty, but the pretence that a noble promise has already solved the problem of power.

> *The brief is not: "Tell me that every system has imperfections." It is: "Find out whether the mechanisms by which we pursue freedom, equality, competence, and safety repeatedly manufacture new masters—and whether we can stop them without manufacturing another."*

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Prologue. Stop Confusing the Ideal with the Mechanism

We do not lack promises of liberation. We lack the capacity to prevent the liberator from becoming the owner of liberation. The aristocrat can be replaced by the party secretary; a public monopoly by private infrastructure from which it is impossible to detach ourselves; the censor by the selector of attention. The justification changes, and the severity of abuse and the possibilities of resistance can change enormously. Yet the question remains brutally simple: who becomes dependent on whom, and what does it cost to refuse?

The explanation that an ideal has been betrayed is sometimes true and often insufficient. It saves the doctrine before examining the mechanism. If equalisation requires concentrating the power to distribute resources, the administrator's privilege is not an accident external to equalisation. If contractual freedom permits the accumulation of resources with which other people's options can be closed, dependence does not necessarily come from outside the market. If government requires simplifying problems the public cannot follow in full, the specialist in simplification can become a specialist in manipulation. Not every failure is poor execution. Some are local successes for those in the right position.

A regime cannot answer criticism simply by presenting a worse one. A dependent employee does not become autonomous because they are not living in a labour camp. A press vulnerable to its financiers does not become independent because it receives no daily instructions from a ministry. A partially captured democracy is not absolved by the existence of a complete dictatorship. These differences are decisive for victims and for the possibilities of action. They do not transform a milder form of domination into freedom fulfilled.

We will therefore examine something more uncomfortable than the mistakes of those in power: how an order selects its beneficiaries, allows them to protect their advantages, and then calls the result equality, merit, efficiency, or the popular will. An institution can work badly for society and extremely well for the coalition that controls it. In that situation, recommending that it be “improved” misses the conflict. Its beneficiaries do not share everyone else's definition of improvement.

The thesis is not that every society must collapse. It is that none of the major principles discussed here automatically produces the conditions for its own endurance. Freedom requires people capable of exercising it and resources that make refusal possible. Equality requires limits on the equaliser. Order requires enough power to defend itself,

but not enough to let its defenders become society's owners. When these conditions are consumed faster than they are replenished, a regime can prepare its own negation.

Where there is research, we will use it. Where there is a plausible mechanism, we will state its premises. Where we do not know a magnitude or probability, we will not manufacture a percentage. This does not require a reassuring tone. An insufficiently quantified possibility can be grave, and a systemic risk does not become negligible because we do not yet possess an experiment capable of measuring it at the scale of a civilisation.

The book also adopts a normative limit: people are not disposable material for other people's projects. For that reason, it will not allow rights to replace the discussion of obligations, moral equality to be confused with identical capabilities, or the protection of the vulnerable to become impunity for aggressors. Nor will it accept the reverse operation: turning differences in performance into a caste's entitlement to determine other people's human worth. These two refusals support one another.

We manufacture our own masters when we surrender control in exchange for a promise and call the promise a guarantee. We manufacture them, too, when we reduce freedom to permission to complain after losing the means to change anything. Refusing this arrangement is not an administrative utopia. It is a programme of institutional conflict: power must encounter organised power, not merely better arguments.

1. Antinomies Are Not Accidents

When an idea produces its own adversary

In Kant, the antinomies of pure reason are not simply situations in which we like two things and cannot have both. They arise when reason attempts to settle questions about totalities beyond the conditions of experience and finds itself arguing opposing theses. This book borrows the critical question; it does not claim to apply Kant's architecture demonstratively to politics. Here, “antinomies of governance” refers principally to structural tensions and mechanisms through which a solution undermines its own purpose (Kant, 1781/1787).

A political antinomy, in this sense, becomes interesting when changing the label cannot remove it. If private power buys protection against competition, invoking the free market does not stop the purchase. If the administrator of equality selects those who supervise the administration, invoking equality does not make the administrator controllable. What matters is identifying the feedback loop through which the result of a rule changes that rule to the winner's advantage. Universal inevitability is not necessary for recognising a dangerous, repeatable mechanism.

Three situations must be distinguished. A genuine trade-off arises when, under given conditions, more of one good requires less of another: an additional oversight procedure may delay a decision. An apparent contradiction arises when one word has been used for different things: equality of rights is not equality of income. A self-undermining dynamic arises when the system's initial success erodes the conditions of its operation: competition produces winners who subsequently purchase rules against competition. These situations need different responses. A trade-off must be managed, a confusion clarified, and a mechanism of deterioration interrupted.

Institutions must not be designed only for the reasonable cooperator. They must also withstand the ambitious, vain, opportunistic, and unscrupulous—including when such people are intelligent and competent. An order that works only with decent people has not solved the political problem. It has assumed away the problem for which it was needed. An order that systematically rewards conformity has no right to be surprised when independent people refuse to serve it.

Who gets to define the optimum?

“The good of society” looks like a clear destination until a route must be chosen. Infrastructure can raise average income while destroying communities. A rule can protect a majority while continually humiliating a minority. One generation can become prosperous by consuming the next generation's options. No single indicator

turns these conflicts into a neutral calculation. Choosing the weights is already a political decision.

A simple example reveals a limit of aggregation. Three people rank three projects as follows: the first prefers A to B and B to C; the second prefers B, then C, then A; the third prefers C, then A, then B. A majority prefers A to B, B to C, and C to A. None of the individuals has circular preferences, but majority comparison produces a cycle. Arrow's theorem formalises a more general limitation: with at least three alternatives, certain requirements on ordinal aggregation cannot all be satisfied on an unrestricted domain. Democracy is not thereby impossible. Rather, no aggregation rule can be endowed with every desirable property simultaneously (Arrow, 1951).

For that reason, politics cannot simply be replaced by expertise. An expert can estimate the risks of a dam. Hydrology alone cannot establish what compensation makes the loss of a settlement acceptable. Expertise can identify an efficient solution for a specified objective. It cannot turn the objective itself into a necessary consequence of technical competence.

But voting does not turn every preference into a sound technical assessment either. We may decide democratically what risks to accept; we cannot decide a material's strength by majority vote. A lucid society needs a division of functions: debate over ends, verifiable competence concerning means, oversight of those who implement decisions, and the ability to reopen a decision when its assumptions change.

Is power conserved, or transformed?

Michels formulated the famous thesis that organisations tend towards oligarchy: leaders accumulate expertise, time, control over information, and administrative resources unavailable to ordinary members. It is a powerful warning against the idea that a democratic organisation remains democratic merely because of its origin. However, calling it an “iron law” does not make it a physical law demonstrated for every possible society (Michels, 1911/1915).

This book proposes tracing the conversion of power. Wealth can purchase influence; office can generate wealth; prestige can protect office; information control can manufacture prestige. There is no quantitative law of the conservation of domination. There are, however, enough channels of substitution that removing one inequality does not guarantee the removal of the others. Every reform must be asked which channels it closes and which it leaves open.

Acemoglu and Robinson's model shows why a change in formal political institutions need not redistribute effective power proportionally. Elites losing de jure power can invest in forms of de facto influence, offsetting the reform and preserving economic institutions favourable to themselves. This is a theoretical model, not a verdict that all

democratisation is fraudulent. It nevertheless poses precisely the question omitted by procedural optimism: what does the group losing through reform do to cancel the reform's effects? (Acemoglu and Robinson, 2008).

A capture sequence can be described without mistaking it for a law of history. Advantage produces resources; resources influence selection and rules; rules obstruct new competitors; closure produces rents; rents finance the justification of closure. At the end of this circuit, privilege presents itself as competence, stability, or protection of the public interest. Interrupting it requires finding the point where a legitimate advantage becomes an entitlement to prevent someone else from competing.

It is therefore insufficient to inventory the rights written into a constitution. We must ask who has the time, money, information, protection, and organisation to use them. A right of appeal that cannot be financed remains a right, but it is not yet an effective defence. An economic alternative available only after financial ruin does not eliminate dependence. The gap between a right and the capacity to exercise it is one of domination's principal hiding places.

The rule for analysis throughout this book follows: judge a regime not only by what it enables a benevolent leader to do, but by what it enables a hostile leader to do and by the means through which those affected can stop that leader. A system that continually needs a good person at the top is an invitation to the first sufficiently capable bad one.

2. Equality Confiscated

A nobility without titles

Property can be confiscated. The power to decide who receives a home, who can publish, who is promoted, and who may leave does not disappear with private property. On the contrary, if too many such decisions enter the same hierarchy, eliminating private fortunes can concentrate a power wider than wealth itself. Monetary inequality becomes less visible, while inequality of command becomes harder to contest.

Kornai describes classical socialism through the relationship between party monopoly, state ownership, and bureaucratic coordination. His analysis of shortage and the soft budget constraint shifts explanation from individual administrators' defects to the organisation of the system. That shift is decisive: if an arrangement reproduces incentives that sustain dysfunction, replacing an administrator does not change its cause. Moral outrage at a bureaucrat can leave the bureaucracy that produces such officials untouched (Kornai, 1992).

The privileges of the nomenklatura can thus be understood without reducing them to a difference between two salaries. A modest income accompanied by priority access, informal immunity, and power over another person's career may be worth more than a higher income without those advantages. The accounting of equality becomes fraudulent when it counts only money, not the ability to refuse, contest, and live without someone's protection.

The central problem is the confiscation of equality by its administrator. When the same hierarchy distributes resources, establishes the criteria, and decides whether the distribution may be challenged, income equalisation can coexist with extreme political inequality. Having slightly more or less does not describe the power of someone who decides whether you receive anything. The distinction between a limited redistributive policy and a monopoly over that decision must be preserved: it is the monopoly that turns social protection into generalised dependence.

When truth becomes a career risk

Imagine a manager evaluated on meeting a target known to be unrealistic. Reporting the truth makes the manager look incompetent or disloyal. Lying buys time. The superior faces the same choice at a higher level. Everyone need not believe the lie. It is enough for each person to know that truth creates more exposure than conformity. One possible result is an organisation that possesses the information it needs but cannot use it honestly.

This is a demonstration of a mechanism, not a documentary description of every communist enterprise. It explains why a problem of governance is not merely a problem of computing capacity. People must be able to transmit inconvenient information without destroying their position. The dispersed knowledge of concrete circumstances emphasised by Hayek cannot be reduced to a spreadsheet the centre has not yet received. Some knowledge appears only through trial, exchange, and responses to local conditions (Hayek, 1945).

The retreat of some capable people into mathematics, engineering, or other fields whose results were harder to replace with slogans is a plausible historical hypothesis close to the experience motivating this book. It is not treated here as a demonstrated occupational distribution across all communist regimes. The mechanism is nevertheless worth stating: if independent social analysis is dangerous while technical performance remains useful to those in power, talent is pushed towards areas in which truth can be practised without claiming authority over political conclusions. Society retains the specialist and loses the intellectual citizen.

The price is not only economic. People learn to speak one way in public and another at home, to call something a success while knowing it has failed, and to calculate honesty as a professional risk. This is an interpretation of a mechanism of degradation, not a measurement of every biography. It explains how the violence of an order can survive in habitual responses: suspicion, cynicism, performed obedience, contempt for rules, and the conviction that every success conceals a connection. Material poverty does not exhaust the damage.

What must be acknowledged without absolving the system

The expansion of literacy, education, or services does not cancel political monopoly; political monopoly does not make those achievements nonexistent either. Comparison must ask what was achieved, at what cost, for whom, and relative to which historical alternative. Kornai offers a systemic analysis in which such distinctions can be discussed without a propagandistic balance sheet of “great achievements.” A dictatorship does not retrospectively buy its innocence with a school, just as a school does not disappear because a dictatorship built it (Kornai, 1992).

Cooperation experienced in communities under constraint also deserves to be taken seriously. There is nevertheless a difference between the cooperation produced by a just order and the solidarity people develop to survive a bad one. Helping neighbours because supplies are unreliable does not establish unreliable supplies as a good policy for solidarity. Nor does capitalist competition invalidate every form of cooperation among people living under capitalism.

Equality of dignity does not require erasing differences in contribution. If effort, skill, and responsibility make too little difference to rewards, autonomy, or recognition,

some people restrict their contribution or seek another way out. This is an incentive mechanism, not the claim that money is the only motivation. Subordinating competence to loyalty can be more damaging than compressing salaries: the specialist is asked to excel at implementing decisions they have no right to judge.

Defending socialism by promising a democratic administrator reopens the question rather than settling it. An administrator can be elected and still control the information on which re-election depends. Benefits can be distributed so that voters depend on the administrator's continuation. Opposition can become a material risk. It does not follow that every instance of public ownership produces these effects. It follows that public ownership is not equivalent to effective public control, and “belonging to everyone” can conceal “at the discretion of a few.”

Equality becomes fraudulent when visible differences in wealth are replaced by harder-to-contest differences in the right to decide. Nobility no longer needs a coat of arms. Access, a dossier, an appointment, the right telephone call, and the right not to answer are enough. An order that prohibits declared superiority can make actual superiority less visible and, for that very reason, less controllable.

3. Freedom Sells Its Own Foundations

Markets distribute more than goods

Markets can open genuine opportunities for people without a reserved place in the political hierarchy. That capacity explains the force of the capitalist promise. The question begins after the first success: what prevents the winner from turning resources earned through competition into means of escaping it? A doctrine that describes free entry but treats subsequent closure as an accident analyses the beginning of the game while ignoring the strategy of its winner.

Markets reward what finds solvent demand within a set of rules and starting positions. That is different from rewarding everything valuable to human beings. Indispensable work may be poorly paid when those performing it have little bargaining power. A questionable activity may be highly profitable when it exploits a bottleneck or a dependency. These observations do not establish that prices are useless. They establish that a price is not a complete moral tribunal.

Chetty and colleagues' research, using social-network and economic-mobility data from the United States, identifies a strong association between cross-class connections and upward mobility. The finding does not turn every friendship into a causal experiment. It does challenge the sufficiency of the image of an individual succeeding through isolated effort: access to people, information, and social environments is part of the structure of opportunity (Chetty et al., 2022).

Films about differences between rich and poor teenagers are not statistical evidence. They are useful here as an intuition about how class can become an experience of humiliation before it becomes an economic category. The researchable question concerns the advantages transmitted through relationships, schooling, security, time, and access. When success is explained exclusively through individual merit, these conditions vanish from the account, and the defeated are asked to regard society's verdict as an exact assessment of their personal worth.

The corporation as private government

Elizabeth Anderson uses the idea of private government to analyse employers' power over workers and workers' lack of voice in decisions shaping their lives. Her argument is philosophical and institutional: an organisation's private status does not make the domination exercised inside it irrelevant (E. Anderson, 2017).

A corporation and a totalitarian state are not the same. They differ in the scope of coercion, rights outside the organisation, and possibilities of exit. This distinction does not refute the observation about power exercised within an organisation. A person can

live in a democracy and spend a decisive part of life in a hierarchy where challenging a superior threatens their livelihood. Signing a contract does not make the problem disappear. We must examine the real alternatives available before signing and the protections retained afterwards (E. Anderson, 2017).

Being legally able to leave is not the same as being able to leave without ruin. A family dependent on one salary, a person with few savings, or a specialist in a town with only one relevant employer may possess very different levels of formal freedom and effective autonomy. The antinomy appears when an order justified by individual choice permits positions from which other people's choices can be controlled.

Conformity does not require a central committee. In Prendergast's model, subjective employee evaluation can create an incentive to report what an employee believes the superior wants to hear. Every boss need not order a lie. If agreement is rewarded and a difficult-to-verify disagreement is penalised, an organisation can manufacture its own yes-men (Prendergast, 1993).

This observation gives precision to the resemblance between party bureaucracy and certain corporate hierarchies: not an identity of regimes, but a shared problem of information selection and professional survival. When promotion depends on willingness to validate decisions from above, reality becomes subordinate to careers. When leaders then interpret the absence of objections as proof of their own judgement, the institution mistakes the fear it has produced for the consensus it has obtained.

Hierarchy can be useful for coordination. Its usefulness does not establish an unlimited entitlement of the superior over the person being coordinated. Separating the authority necessary for a task from power over the executor's entire life is a political requirement, not a managerial whim. An employment contract should not become a licence to humiliate, and invoking performance should not make it impossible to scrutinise whoever defines performance.

When the winner buys the rules

Competition needs rules preventing its winners from closing it down. Without them, economic success can be converted into influence over regulation, information infrastructure, and access for new competitors. A market defended exclusively through the power of already powerful actors risks losing its mechanism of discovery.

Gilens and Page analysed 1,779 US policy issues from 1981–2002. In their model, the preferences of economic elites and certain interest groups had a substantial independent association with policy changes, while the preferences of average citizens had little independent influence after those controls. The study is important, but does not prove that voting never matters: group preferences overlap, issue selection matters, and observational inference has limits (Gilens and Page, 2014).

Meritocratic hypocrisy begins when inherited advantage, protected access, and influence over the rules are presented as pure results of effort. It does two kinds of damage simultaneously: hiding privilege's mechanism and insulting those who lose by asking them to regard themselves as solely responsible. Dismantling that operation does not require denying merit. On the contrary, merit is one of its victims: a closed system borrows its prestige to justify outcomes that open competition might overturn.

Libertarianism encounters a contradiction here that “less state” does not resolve. If public power retreats while ownership and infrastructure remain concentrated, the disappearance of an authority does not mean the disappearance of power. Power may pass to actors over whom those affected have even fewer political rights. And if a state is required to be strong enough to guarantee property but too weak to limit property's effects of domination, the doctrine's neutrality becomes questionable.

Democratic liberalism adds elections, rights, and public correction. Its problem is not that these things are irrelevant, but that they can be consumed from within by economic power allowed to purchase access, influence, and dependence. Research on the persistence of power provides a model of this compensation between formal institutions and effective resources (Acemoglu and Robinson, 2008). Under certain conditions, economic success can finance the political destruction of the conditions that made it legitimate. Simply celebrating entrepreneurship does not repair this defect.

4. Censorship Without a Censor

You can speak. That does not mean you can be heard

Freedom of expression can remain legally intact while the freedom to form an informed judgement deteriorates. A text need not be prohibited if it can be buried in more content than anyone can read. An argument need not be refuted if the public no longer has time to follow it. Being unheard does not by itself establish censorship. The political problem arises when control over distribution systematically makes some forms of expression almost invisible and others unavoidable.

“Censorship through noise” will refer here to two distinct mechanisms. The first is intentional: an actor floods public space to prevent attention from organising around an inconvenient issue. The second is emergent: commercial rules and individual behaviour produce an environment in which careful content requiring effort to assess competes at a disadvantage against quick stimuli. The first requires evidence of strategy. The second can operate without a centre that planned it.

King, Pan, and Roberts studied the fabrication of social-media posts by Chinese authorities. Their findings emphasise strategic distraction and favourable messaging rather than only argumentative confrontation with critics. The study provides a documented example of the first mechanism. It does not justify the deduction that every wave of entertainment or trivial topic in a democracy is a coordinated operation (King et al., 2017).

Media ownership is power over the conditions through which others learn what is happening. Djankov and colleagues' comparative study of major media organisations in 97 countries identified the dominant roles of state and family ownership. It is a historical snapshot, not an inventory of today's media, and the authors found particularly unfavourable outcomes associated with state ownership. The evidence therefore does not support the claim that all ownership forms are equivalent. It supports examining who owns the infrastructure of information, not merely which freedoms a constitution declares (Djankov et al., 2003).

An owner need not write every article to influence a publication. The appointment of management, investigative budgets, protection offered to journalists, and acceptance of commercial risk delimit what can become routine editorial practice. This is an organisational mechanism, not an accusation that every newsroom receives orders. Professionalism can resist pressure, but resistance has a cost. Independence that lasts only as long as a financier remains generous is not institutionally guaranteed independence.

Noise has an advantage over classical censorship: it preserves the appearance of abundance and makes any single prohibition difficult to identify. Truth can be accessible without being encountered, distinguished, or verified by someone who has exhausted the energy needed to check it. In such an environment, power need not own every voice. Controlling the relationship between their volume and the available attention may be enough.

An algorithm is not another word for conspiracy

Vosoughi, Roy, and Aral found that false news in their sample of fact-checked stories circulating on Twitter spread faster and more widely than true news. Their analysis concerns that dataset, not every message on the internet. It reveals an asymmetry in circulation, not a measurement of the population's intelligence (Vosoughi et al., 2018).

Rathje and colleagues found a strong association between hostility towards the opposing group and sharing in political and media posts. Robertson and colleagues used experimental headline tests to show that negativity can increase news consumption. Together, these studies support an incentive problem: attention can reward conflict and negative framing without tracking truth or public usefulness (Rathje et al., 2021; Robertson et al., 2023).

It is nevertheless too easy to turn this observation into a universal explanation of polarisation. Guess and colleagues' 2023 experiment concerning Facebook and Instagram during the 2020 US campaign found that switching to a chronological feed changed exposure and use without significant effects on measured political attitudes over the studied period. By contrast, Gauthier and colleagues reported political effects in 2026 from switching on X's algorithmic feed in a 2023 experiment. Platforms, interventions, and contexts are not interchangeable (Guess et al., 2023; Gauthier et al., 2026).

These findings permit a firm but bounded statement: distribution architecture can have political consequences, and its effects are not uniform or necessarily reversed by changing one setting. The X study did not find significant effects on every political indicator, including affective polarisation. We do not have a demonstrated machine for total mind control. We have something serious enough: the power to selectively alter the informational environment, sometimes with measurable effects on users' positions (Gauthier et al., 2026).

The majority—or those who select its appearance?

Calling this entire phenomenon “the tyranny of the majority” may miss an important part of the problem. What looks like majority opinion can result from disproportionately active minorities, platform selection, or purchased visibility. The number of reactions does not automatically represent the number of citizens. Their

intensity does not establish an issue's importance. Time spent does not establish approval of content.

The mechanism does not necessarily select majority opinion. It may select willingness to react, intensity of hostility, and organisational efficiency. Stupidity no longer needs to win an argument to become influential; being repeatable, exciting, and cheap to distribute may suffice. The same applies to well-packaged pseudo-erudition. A degree does not rescue a message. Its contact with evidence and capacity for correction do. An educated audience can amplify a sophisticated error with the same satisfaction with which another audience repeats a slogan.

Freedom of expression cannot be defended by a ministry of truth deciding definitively what must be seen. Nor can it be defended by the dogma that private selection has no public consequences. A more robust direction would involve genuinely plural intermediaries, portable relationships, a choice of recommender systems, researcher access to appropriately protected data, and transparent political advertising. These are institutional proposals, not remedies with universally demonstrated effectiveness.

They carry costs. Transparency may help those manipulating a system; data access may threaten privacy; user-selected personalisation may deepen isolation. Each measure therefore needs limits and evaluation. The objective is not to force everyone to think deeply every moment. It is to prevent a small number of centres from deciding, opaquely and without alternatives, what can become a shared public concern.

A society can produce more expression than listening, more certainty than verification, and more outrage than action. This is the institutional hypothesis of degradation through noise: the scarce good is no longer the opportunity to publish, but attention capable of judgement. Whoever controls its allocation can exercise power without explicitly accepting the role of censor. The remedy is not merely another source of content. It is a set of selection institutions that do not all depend on the same interest, and a public with real time to use them.

5. The Mandarins Will Not Save Us

Expertise can become caste property

Competent people have good reasons to fear decisions made in ignorance. Everyone else has equally serious reasons to fear a caste that certifies its own competence and demands power in its name. This antinomy cannot be resolved by choosing between stupidity and expertise. As far as possible, it is addressed by preventing expertise from becoming a title of ownership over decisions, and participation from becoming a right to ignore consequences.

The mandarin, as an institutional type used here, is not simply a learned person. It is someone who masters the code of recognition and can substitute it for judgement: the acceptable bibliography, vocabulary, evaluation rituals, alliances, and forms in which agreement must be delivered. The analogy is not a history of Chinese administration. It is a critique of any organisation in which proving membership of a circle becomes more important than proving that a problem has been understood.

Competence presents an evaluation paradox. Recognising it requires some competence. The public inevitably uses signals: qualifications, reputations, institutions, and recommendations. Signals can be useful without being perfect. When they become the only accepted currency, an incentive appears to invest more in the signal than in the capacity it is supposed to represent. An intelligent critique does not demand the abolition of expertise, but periodic testing of the relationship between signals and results.

Independent thought is costly. It produces failed attempts, ideas not yet well formulated, and periods in which the thinker appears less certain than the imitator. An institution demanding both novelty and the absence of reputational risk will often select cosmetic novelty. This is an organisational-selection hypothesis: research and administration can reward the legible appearance of competence at competence's expense. Not every eccentric is right. The problem is that a hierarchy of conformity lacks the incentive even to find out.

The yes-men model is relevant here too. If an evaluator cannot directly observe quality, agreement with the evaluator's opinion may become a convenient substitute. The subordinate is then encouraged to guess the evaluator's preference rather than examine the world. Prendergast provides an economic model of this distortion; applying it to universities or political institutions is an analytical extension requiring verification in each context (Prendergast, 1993).

A caste of experts can defend itself against criticism in two incompatible but convenient ways. When challenged by non-specialists, it invokes their lack of training;

when challenged by specialists, it invokes institutional consensus. If no type of critic is admissible, expertise has become closed authority. Genuine competence needs criteria by which it can be disproved and rivals whose careers do not depend on the person being evaluated.

How much pluralism can a decision withstand?

Too few perspectives can leave an error undiscovered. Too many centres with veto power can prevent any action. Invoking consensus does not resolve this tension, because consensus can mean either informed convergence or silence obtained through pressure. Disagreement is not a virtue in itself either. Sometimes it reveals a problem; sometimes it protects interests that benefit from delay.

One conceptual response is to separate stages. Exploration benefits from multiple options, contradictions, and experiments. Execution requires clear responsibilities and some stability. Evaluation must reopen access to criticism, including from those who lost the original dispute. Confusing these stages produces either a society that discusses endlessly or one that endlessly executes an error.

Another distinction concerns reversibility. An administrative interface can be tested locally. Destroying an ecosystem or removing a constitutional safeguard cannot be treated as an ordinary product experiment. For the first category, tolerance of error may be high. For the second, additional time and independent scrutiny may be forms of rationality rather than mere bureaucratic obstacles.

Useful plurality does not mean unlimited vetoes. It means that important assumptions can be challenged before a decision becomes irreversible, and that execution cannot suppress evaluation. An organisation can have clear command and plural analysis, just as it can have endless meetings and uniform thought. A mature institution does not confuse unity of action with uniformity of mind.

Popular decision-making without the cult of infallibility

Democracy is not valuable because the majority is always competent or moral. A more durable argument is that affected people have standing as participants, power can be contested, and succession need not be settled through violence. These functions may operate imperfectly and may be eroded. Their lack of an absolute guarantee does not make them irrelevant.

Economic findings do not support a simple condemnation of democracy either. Acemoglu, Naidu, Restrepo, and Robinson estimate substantial positive long-run effects of democratisation on GDP per capita within their identification strategy. Their result does not establish that every democratisation produces prosperity, that the effect is immediate, or that all democratic institutions are alike. It is nevertheless an empirical

reason not to present authoritarianism as a general precondition for development (Acemoglu et al., 2019).

Expert administration should be stronger in formulating and testing means, not immune when setting ends. Competent administration needs protection from arbitrary partisan purges and exposure to independent evaluation. Time-limited mandates, plural evaluators, publication of reasoned dissent, and separation of advice from budgetary control are possible mechanisms. Each can be manipulated; none replaces judgement about the particular case.

Numbers present an important limit. Indicators are necessary to avoid governing exclusively through impressions. But when careers depend on one indicator, there is an incentive to sacrifice what it omits. The literature on incentives in multitask activities formalises this problem: strongly rewarding an easily measured dimension can divert effort from important but difficult-to-measure dimensions (Holmström and Milgrom, 1991).

Culture does not make an intellectual incorruptible, and numbers do not make a crowd lucid. Nevertheless, competence must be used and decisions must be made. Naming a caste “those who know” offers no escape from the tension. There is only a discipline of authority: those who assert must explain; those who decide must answer; those who evaluate must be capable of losing control over evaluation. An expert who accepts none of these conditions is asking for sovereignty, not respect for knowledge.

6. Resentment: The Raw Material of Power

When promises grow faster than positions

The promise that learning and hard work lead to success can cultivate ambition and produce a mass of people who feel cheated. The problem arises when society expands access to credentials and aspirations while keeping the positions that bring money, influence, and respect scarce. It sells everyone a ladder that cannot carry everyone to the top. Some of those left below demand fairer rules. Others begin to prefer overturning the rules altogether.

The structural-demographic theory associated with Peter Turchin connects pressures on living standards, elite competition, and difficulties confronting the state. A retrospective paper published in 2020 examines forecasts made for the preceding decade. It is an interesting research programme, not a universally accepted historical law. Indicator selection, the definition of elites, and predictive performance beyond the cases analysed remain substantive problems (Turchin and Korotayev, 2020).

Elite overproduction does not mean that society has too much intelligence. It means that it produces more claimants to rank than recognised places in the hierarchy. The distinction is decisive. A society can use enormous amounts of competence while distributing prestige as a monopoly. Education then does not automatically become productive cooperation; it can become competence in contestation, organisation, and the justification of a new domination. This hypothesised mechanism makes the theory interesting—not the promise of a reliable timetable of crises (Turchin and Korotayev, 2020).

An excluded aspirant can sincerely criticise injustice. The same person can also discover that a radical ideology offers a faster route to power than existing competition. The motives may combine. We need not choose between a romantic portrait of the pure revolutionary and a cynical portrait of the absolute opportunist. For institutional design, the more useful questions concern the rewards offered for mobilising hostility and the peaceful routes available to legitimate ambition.

Poverty has no monopoly on resentment

Resentment directed at culture, rules, and the middle class can exist and must be named when it appears. Someone may desire not the correction of injustice but the humiliation of a person who reminds them of their own failure. At the same time, parts of the middle class may turn respectability into contempt for those without resources,

while an educated aspirant converts envy into a universal doctrine. These are mechanisms and forms of behaviour, not natural traits of entire classes. Generalising by income would conceal the distinction between legitimate grievance, opportunism, and the pleasure of punishment.

Diana Mutz's study of the 2016 US vote emphasised status threat rather than individual economic hardship. Stephen Morgan's reanalysis challenged the delineation and causal interpretation of some findings. The dispute is instructive: status and material interest can be connected, and a striking title does not allow one dataset to eliminate every other explanation (Mutz, 2018; Morgan, 2018).

Autor and colleagues' research on exposure to import competition documents electoral consequences of local economic shocks. Margalit's review likewise argues for examining economic insecurity without making it an exhaustive explanation of populism. Resentment can have material, symbolic, and relational roots; their relative weight varies (Autor et al., 2020; Margalit, 2019).

Explaining resentment does not declare it innocent. Humiliation can have real causes and still fuel illegitimate demands to dominate others. Being treated unjustly does not give someone a right over a neighbour's freedom. Lucid politics must be able to say both things without hesitation: you were disadvantaged, and what you now want to do to others remains abusive.

Divide and rule without an omnipotent scriptwriter

Divide and rule requires no omniscient centre. An actor can observe who fears whom, who despises whom, and which conflict distracts potential opponents. The actor can fund messengers, select convenient incidents, and hide the parties' dependence on the same infrastructure of power. Some conflicts are instrumentalised in this way; others arise independently. The effect can be identical: people who could challenge privilege are kept busy challenging one another's dignity.

The strategy can escape its initiator's control. A politician legitimising hostility for a limited advantage may be overtaken by another willing to promise more punishment. A mobilised public does not remain the property of whoever mobilised it. The idea that traditional elites can indefinitely use extremists without being used by them is a hypothesis about control, not a guarantee.

One capture scenario deserves to be followed to its conclusion. An economic elite supports an aggressive mobilisation to weaken inconvenient rules. The mobilisation produces leaders who learn that escalation brings attention and loyalty. Those leaders then demand control of institutions, not merely a policy change. When the original patrons try to stop the process, they discover that the organised public responds to a new centre. This scenario does not demonstrate that every conservative alliance or

social protest follows this route. It shows why treating extremism as a controllable instrument is a dangerous wager.

A dangerous leader does not need a clinical diagnosis to be recognised politically. What matters is behaviour: promising impunity to supporters, turning opponents into enemies without rights, normalising intimidation, and claiming that a mandate outranks the rules that made it possible. The ability to exploit cruelty and resentment can be a genuine political competence. It should not be confused with incompetence or treated as a simple lack of education.

Part of the response concerns the distribution of opportunities, not only incomes. Society must allow new enterprises, access to professions, challenges to credential monopolies, and forms of recognition that do not require occupying the political centre. Another part concerns the credibility of sanctions: rules that punish only the unprotected become recruitment material for demagogues.

But a fairer distribution does not eliminate all resentment. Status is relational: someone can become richer and still feel diminished if another advances faster. The psychological literature reviewed by Anderson, Hildreth, and Howland supports the broad importance of the desire for status. It does not establish that everyone desires domination or that every society must be organised around a single hierarchy (C. Anderson et al., 2015).

No redistribution can guarantee everyone superiority over others. Here the convenient explanation that every resentment would disappear with a better distribution of income reaches its limit. A decent order must offer multiple routes to contribution and respect. A realistic order must also be able to stop the person who refuses respect without domination. Some demands can be satisfied. Others require keeping someone underneath. Treating the two identically is a failure of governance.

7. Liberalism Does Not Reproduce Itself

Who transmits the conditions of freedom?

A liberal order needs people capable of tolerating frustration, respecting rules when they lose, distinguishing argument from intimidation, and investing in the next generation. It does not receive such people automatically from nature, nor produce them merely by proclaiming rights. If the ways of life it rewards weaken the transmission of these capacities, freedom may consume the social capital on which it lives. This is a serious problem of institutional reproduction, not a subject that disappears when it becomes uncomfortable.

The severe hypothesis is this: when groups investing heavily in education and assuming high costs of care have low fertility, while a growing share of children is raised with insufficient investment and norms incompatible with liberal reciprocity, the future distribution of skills and civic support may deteriorate. For the process to persist, schooling, mobility, and cultural change must fail to compensate sufficiently. Stated this way, the argument is conditional and researchable. It requires no assumption that a class or community possesses an inferior biological essence.

Cognitive ability, education, work discipline, income, and allegiance to rules are distinct variables. Their differences matter politically precisely because none can be obtained by declaring another. A person can be intelligent and hostile to other people's freedom; someone else can have little schooling and strong civic discipline. Equality of rights does not imply equality of aptitude or contribution. Politics must work with this heterogeneity, neither denying it nor reducing it to a single ranking.

Two questions must be separated. Can the distribution of socially important capacities and norms change unfavourably? And does the existing literature allow such a process to be attributed to the stable biological inferiority of social categories? The first has plausible mechanisms and relevant findings to investigate. The studies discussed here do not support that generalisation in answer to the second. The institutional risk must not be abandoned because a totalising biological explanation has not been demonstrated.

Differential fertility and the cost of raising a person

In de la Croix and Doepke's intergenerational model, fertility and investment in children's education are jointly determined. Under the conditions analysed, low-income families have more children and invest less in each child's education; widening fertility differentials can reduce average human-capital accumulation and economic growth. The authors also confront the mechanism with data. This is not a genetic

demonstration, but a theoretical and empirical link between inequality, family size, and the resources invested in children's development (de la Croix and Doepke, 2003).

The implication for this book's argument is uncomfortable: declaring every child's equal right to development is not enough. We must ask whether society can actually deliver that development as the distribution of needs changes. A right may be universal while the resources and time needed to implement it are insufficient. Denying the difference between moral intention and material capacity does not protect children. It can leave deteriorating conditions of upbringing unnoticed.

Nor is the highly educated family an inexhaustible reproductive resource. If lengthy professional training, housing, insecurity, and demanding standards of care make parenthood difficult to reconcile with the life society recommends, individual success may conflict with collective continuity. This mechanism must be measured, not assumed identical everywhere. But a society demanding maximum investment in every child while severely penalising the time that investment requires cannot declare itself surprised by the outcome.

The response cannot reduce children to their parents' scores. It must address the real costs of care, the quality of education, parental responsibility, and the compatibility of family life with professional contribution. Responsibility can be demanded without turning fertility into an administratively managed competition among categories of citizens. The problem is reproducing capabilities and reciprocity, not producing a state-accredited caste.

What genetics does—and does not—show

Using Icelandic data, Kong and colleagues found an association between a polygenic score for educational attainment, later reproduction, and fewer children, alongside a modest change in the average score across the cohorts analysed. Hiding this finding would be as wrong as attributing more to it than it establishes. It supports the existence of selection pressures associated with educational traits in that context, not a complete prediction of future generations' intelligence or civic behaviour (Kong et al., 2017).

An educational-attainment score is not a pure measure of intelligence and explains only part of the variation. Okbay and colleagues' study of approximately three million people shows important differences between predictive associations across families and estimates from within-family comparisons. Environment and correlations between environment and genotype enter the interpretation. Identifying an association does not mean isolating a biological mechanism sufficient to support a political conclusion (Okbay et al., 2022).

Heritability describes variation within a population and environment under specified assumptions. It does not fix a child's destiny or automatically explain differences

between groups. This limit does not imply unlimited plasticity: promising that any educational intervention can produce any outcome would be equally unjustified. A rigorous position rejects both convenient certainties—the completely predetermined person and the infinitely reprogrammable person.

In the Swedish male cohorts they studied, Kolk and Barclay found an overall positive relationship between cognitive ability measured at conscription and number of children. This excludes the convenient assumption of a universally negative relationship. It does not eliminate possible mechanisms in other contexts. It requires analysis to specify sex, cohort, institutions, and partnership formation rather than turning a local observation into a law of human decline (Kolk and Barclay, 2019).

Environment changes what we measure

Ritchie and Tucker-Drob's meta-analysis, based on studies using quasi-experimental strategies, supports positive effects of additional education on cognitive-test performance. Estimates vary across included studies. They do not justify unlimited linear extrapolation, but they contradict the idea that schooling merely sorts completely fixed abilities (Ritchie and Tucker-Drob, 2018).

Bratsberg and Rogeberg analysed the rise and subsequent decline of cognitive scores in Norwegian male cohorts. Comparisons between brothers indicated a central role for environmental factors in the observed trend. This does not mean that genes never matter or that no population can experience slow genetic changes. It means a simple story about demographic composition does not adequately explain that case (Bratsberg and Rogeberg, 2018).

A demographic scenario must therefore state what it holds constant: fertility, education, cultural transmission, mobility, or the probability of changing beliefs. If these are all arbitrarily frozen, the conclusion may merely reproduce the assumptions. If their evolution is assumed automatically favourable, optimism is equally artificial. The serious question is not whether environment matters, but whether a particular environment has the capacity and willingness to offset the pressures identified.

The transmission of anti-liberal norms is a separate problem. A family or organisation can train people in obedience, hostility towards dissenters, and the subordination of outsiders. If such norms are transmitted effectively and benefit from the protection of an order they aim to close, tolerance can be used against its own conditions. Criticism must address practices and their relationship to freedom, whatever religious, secular, or identity-based justification they invoke.

Bisin and Verdier's model treats the transmission of cultural preferences as an outcome of family socialisation and environmental influence, not simple biological copying. Their interaction can sustain diversity, not merely produce victory for the initially

larger group. That is why the model is useful: a political projection must ask how intensively norms are transmitted, which alternatives children encounter, and how families respond to their social environment (Bisin and Verdier, 2001).

The model does not establish that a particular community will inevitably dominate. It produces a question liberalism cannot avoid: tolerance and intolerance may be transmitted with different intensities. An order treating its continuity as spontaneous may lose ground to organisations deliberately investing in loyalty, discipline, and their members' informational isolation. The hypothesis requires indicators and comparisons, not declarations about a population's destiny.

Not every form of capture even requires a demographic majority. Where a dispersed majority faces a well-organised minority, coordination and intimidation costs can matter more than raw population share. The risk must be analysed as a problem of organisation and institutions. Passively waiting for a numerical threshold may miss the point at which the rules have already changed.

Rights, contribution, and protecting freedom's conditions

Fundamental rights are not a prize for usefulness. They are limits on what power may do to a person. Benefits, mandates, offices, and de facto immunities must nevertheless be evaluated separately. A right to protection does not imply a right to attack others, abandon responsibility for children, or prevent someone from leaving a community. Confusing these categories creates a false choice between disarming society and abolishing legal equality.

The normative position adopted here preserves basic legal protection regardless of intelligence, income, or fertility, while demanding accountability for conduct. Competence can be a criterion for office; violence can be punished; childcare entails obligations; access to common resources requires justifiable rules. Neither a qualification nor vulnerability should purchase impunity, directly or through a moral detour.

Reasonable policies begin with concrete differences in need and capacity: quality education, child protection, real opportunities to provide care, free reproductive choices, and enforcement of common rules. None works through a budget allocation alone. Evaluation must ask whether education produces skills, responsibility is assumed, and vulnerable community members can refuse control exercised over them. Compassion without checking outcomes can sustain the dependency it claims to reduce.

Liberalism that fails to reproduce competence, reciprocity, and willingness to defend common rules can turn its freedom into a resource for its most organised opponents. That is the strong political argument. It remains a risk even without a demonstrated

genetic decline in intelligence. Prosperity cannot substitute for civic education, and an abundance of declared rights cannot substitute for people and institutions able to sustain them.

Neither the reassuring story that integration and education will happen by themselves nor the deterministic story of inevitable biological deterioration is justified. What needs defending is not a hereditary ranking of people, but society's capacity to form competent, responsible, and free adults. That capacity can be lost. This book does not assume its automatic regeneration.

8. Chinese Order and the Price of Obedience

Disapproval cannot erase performance

A critic of democracy has a powerful example to invoke: a country governed by a single party achieved an enormous economic transformation. Replying that the outcome does not matter because we dislike the regime would be intellectually dishonest. Turning that outcome into a validation of every institution that coexisted with it would be equally dishonest.

The joint 2022 report by the World Bank and China's Development Research Center describes a reduction of close to 800 million in the number of people in China living below $1.90 a day, a historical poverty threshold expressed in 2011 purchasing-power parity. That is not a universal contemporary threshold for a prosperous life. The report relates the transformation to structural economic changes and public interventions; it does not experimentally isolate single-party rule as a sufficient explanation (World Bank and DRC, 2022).

Continuity, infrastructure coordination, and the ability to concentrate resources are possible advantages, not illusions that disappear when a regime is disapproved of. A democracy paralysed by vetoes, patronage appointments, and unfulfilled promises cannot win the comparison through vocabulary. But state capacity and the absence of freedom must be analysed separately. What produces effective execution, and which political costs are presented as indispensable without being demonstrated to be so?

China is not a single frozen policy. Reforms, markets, trade integration, and changes in administration make it impossible to treat the entire period as an experiment in a constant doctrine. Comparing actual China with an ideal democracy is unfair. Comparing China's successes only with democracies' failures repeats the same mistake in reverse.

Merit, connections, and information that never travels upwards

The image of a pure administrative meritocracy does not survive unqualified. Jia, Kudamatsu, and Seim analysed the promotion of Chinese provincial leaders and found complementarity between performance and political connections. Their study does not establish that performance is fictitious. It establishes that relationships and merit should not be imagined as mutually exclusive alternatives. Someone can be both competent and connected, with connections affecting how competence is recognised (Jia et al., 2015).

Concentrated power has a dangerous asymmetry: it can act before society understands, and continue after society understands. If unwelcome information threatens its transmitters, the centre receives the world in the form required by subordinate careers. The risk is not merely a poorly informed leader. It is a hierarchy with a collective interest in withholding information until correction has become much more expensive.

Meng, Qian, and Yared's analysis of China's Great Famine of 1959–1961 examines institutional mechanisms of grain procurement and distribution. The case is not used here to describe China's present economy. It serves a severe question every project of centralisation must face: how large can the harm become before those affected can change the rule producing it? An administration's average performance does not exhaust the assessment of its catastrophic risks (Meng et al., 2015).

The problem is not only who governs well, but who can be replaced in time. A capable leader can become rigid; a selection system can favour loyalty; succession can eliminate precisely the rival competent enough to correct the centre. Calling this meritocracy does not answer who verifies merit or what that verifier loses when the assessment is wrong. Governance cannot rest on the hope that the right biography will continue indefinitely.

The Universal Party of God

Consider, as a serious thought experiment, a Universal Party of God. Assume excellent moral intentions, not a caricature. The party promises to overcome market selfishness, electoral corruption, and relativism by applying a true order. The immediate question is not whether God exists, but who interprets divine will on fiscal, medical, technological, and military matters.

If the party alone decides the meaning of goodness, competence, and God's will, infallibility becomes a technology for closing contestation. If it accepts an independent body able to declare it wrong and stop it, the problem of that body's power returns. If citizens can refuse, the party no longer possesses the moral monopoly it promised. The experiment is not a joke about faith. It demonstrates conceptually that an absolute name does not eliminate the human interpreter or the interpreter's interests.

The same test applies to a Party of Science, a Party of the Perfect Market, or an artificial intelligence presented as an oracle. Who defines the objective, validates the data, and controls implementation? Who can show that the translation of principle into decision was mistaken? Renaming authority does not remove the chain of delegation.

Neither the market, science, politically invoked divinity, nor AI eliminates the intermediary deciding which conclusion matters and which sacrifice is permissible. An authority can use genuinely moral language and still turn its interpretation into privilege. The question remains: what happens to the person who rejects the official

translation of the good? If the answer is compulsory subordination, domination has merely been renamed.

The authoritarian model demands evaluation by its capacity to deliver and must also be evaluated by its capacity to impose disaster. The democratic model demands evaluation by freedom and must also be evaluated by how it allows freedom to be emptied of substance. Neither can unilaterally choose only the convenient indicator. Serious comparison places performance, correction costs, the distribution of power, and the risk of abuse in the same discussion without pretending that a single score can absorb them without remainder.

9. Cosmolocalism Under the Threat of Force

Global knowledge, local capacity

Cosmolocalism begins from an attractive intuition: knowledge can circulate globally while significant parts of production and decision-making move closer to the communities using them. Designs, standards, and improvements are shared; objects and services are adapted locally. The “design global, manufacture local” literature explores this combination. It does not demonstrate a complete society that has resolved all its conflicts through it (Kostakis et al., 2015).

The conceivable advantage is greater independence without intellectual isolation. A workshop can reuse a global design, a town can adapt an administrative tool, and a community can repair equipment without permission from a sole supplier. Open knowledge can reduce entry costs and allow improvements to accumulate in a distributed way.

But a file is not an object. Energy, materials, skills, quality control, infrastructure, and responsibility for defects are necessary. Some processes have powerful economies of scale. Others create externalities crossing community boundaries. Local production does not automatically mean cheap, safe, or environmentally sound production. Cosmolocalism becomes credible when it chooses the appropriate scale for each function, not when it makes locality a universal virtue.

Common knowledge does not guarantee autonomy if an actor controls execution: energy, equipment, connectivity, certification, or market access. Someone can legally possess a file and materially lack any means of using it. Cosmolocalism must therefore be judged by the distributed capacity to produce and refuse, not merely by a design's licence. Otherwise, a common intellectual inheritance can remain usable only by renting access from a few owners.

Small communities are not immune to domination

Ostrom showed that common resources can be governed through institutional arrangements more varied than a simple market–state opposition. Monitoring, adapted rules, and polycentric structures can support cooperation. The conclusion is not that people cooperate spontaneously everywhere, but that self-organisation works under identifiable institutional conditions (Ostrom, 2010).

A small community can be easier to understand and harder to leave. When employer, creditor, relative, landlord, and moral arbiter belong to the same network, dissent

threatens more than one contract: it threatens an entire life. This is a design risk, not a verdict on every community. Localism becomes oppressive when proximity concentrates dependencies and intimacy makes informal punishment more effective than a written prohibition.

Bardhan and Mookherjee's model of capture at local and national levels shows why decentralisation cannot be assumed automatically to reduce capture. Outcomes depend on the distribution of interests, information, and political mechanisms. A centre can be corrupt; it can also constrain a local abuse that the community cannot correct alone (Bardhan and Mookherjee, 2000).

A free community must therefore also be assessed from the perspective of someone who does not share its dominant norms. Can that person criticise? Leave without confiscation or intimidation? Appeal to an external arbiter? Are children protected against abusive decisions by adults? Without these questions, celebrating local autonomy can become celebrating a small elite's right to remain undisturbed.

Who stops the armed group?

A distributed ledger does not prevent an armed group from confiscating a workshop. A verifiable contract does not by itself produce an independent judge or the capacity to enforce a judgement. If one community can reject common rules and seize resources by force, the others must be able to organise defence. At that moment, the problem decentralisation hoped to remove returns as a material necessity: who coordinates force, and who can stop that coordinator?

Tilly analysed historical relationships between war, resource extraction, and state formation. His argument helps explain the centralising pressure exerted by defence. It is not a theorem that every threat inevitably produces the same kind of state. War can also fragment or destroy political orders (Tilly, 1985).

The coordination problem nevertheless remains. Defence requires resources before the threat is fully visible, shared planning, and a capacity to act. The organisation created for these purposes acquires means it can turn against those it protects. If every community retains an absolute veto, defence can fail. If the centre receives absolute discretion, autonomy can become a fiction.

It would be convenient to answer “a democratic federation” and move on. But a federation needs finance, command, intelligence, and continuity. Administrators of these functions may demand greater discretion in the name of speed and secrecy. Communities may accept dependency to avoid defeat. The defender becomes indispensable, and indispensability can become a claim to sovereignty. This does not establish inevitability. It identifies the centralising pressure that any credible cosmolocalism must withstand.

A solution that disperses weapons without constructing accountability can produce coercive competition rather than freedom. A solution concentrating every means of force without preserving countervailing powers can produce pacification through submission. This is the project's hardest point: common force must be coherent enough to stop aggression and limited enough not to become the aggressor. No protocol trick replaces the political relationship between those commanding and those bearing the consequences.

One partial response distinguishes operational unity of force from plurality in its authorisation. A federation can maintain coherent command while distributing the budget, mandate, oversight, and sanctions among distinct institutions. This is an architectural proposal, not an infallible mechanism. Institutions can collaborate in abuse; a genuine emergency can make procedures too slow; a manufactured emergency can suspend them.

The monopoly of violence must therefore be decomposed. The same person need not control the definition of threats, use of force, financing, and adjudication of consequences. Yet separation on paper is worth little if every institution depends on the same appointments, revenues, and information infrastructure.

Cosmolocalism remains promising as a distribution of productive capacities and access to knowledge. That does not make it a complete theory of order. It needs protection for dissenters, conflict resolution between communities, and defence against coercion. All introduce translocal power. The project earns credibility not by declaring the centre eliminated, but by showing exactly which centres remain, what they can do, and who can refuse them.

10. Feudalism with Terms and Conditions

The promise of government without politics

A recurring temptation for people disappointed by democracy is to replace politics with administration. If a city were run like a company, the argument goes, its leader would have a clear interest: property values, revenues, and the satisfaction of people who can leave. Endless conflicts would give way to managerial responsibility. Electoral promises would yield to verifiable results.

In his “Patchwork” writings, published as Mencius Moldbug, Curtis Yarvin describes variants of corporate sovereignty and governance by shareholder-controlled entities. In *The Dark Enlightenment*, Nick Land develops a radical critique of democracy and assigns a central role to exit. These are doctrinal sources, not research empirically validating the arrangement's superiority (Moldbug, 2008; Land, 2012).

The neoreactionary promise should be considered in its strongest form: leadership accountable for a territory's performance, rapid decisions, jurisdictional competition, and exit instead of permanent electoral conflict. The problem begins when “accountable” means accountable to an owner rather than a resident. Efficient leadership and the freedom of those governed are not the same variable. An administration can be impeccable at achieving an objective that residents have no right to challenge (Moldbug, 2008; Land, 2012).

But the company–state analogy changes its object along the way. An ordinary company operates within a legal framework it does not fully control. A corporate sovereign would control precisely the framework that normally limits a company. Justifying power through a company's virtues while removing the external courts, rules, and rights that discipline it preserves the name and changes the mechanism.

A customer can leave. Can a citizen refuse?

Exit is a genuine instrument of freedom. Other communities, employers, or platforms can constrain abuse. Its effectiveness nevertheless depends on resources, portable assets, alternatives, and relational costs. A person is not a subscription. People have children, friends, obligations, a language, a home, and a history that cannot be moved instantly.

If a jurisdiction selects residents for profitability and exports its social costs, its performance may result from selection rather than demonstrate universally applicable governance. Where do the unprofitable, sick, ageing, and no longer consenting go? A political theory cannot close its accounts at the community gate. Those outside the showcase continue to exist and continue to need an order.

This does not mean that every private city would be abusive. It means that financial interest does not necessarily coincide with an equal right to protection. A resident's welfare may be a means of preserving an asset's value rather than a moral constraint on the owner. The two may coincide for years and diverge precisely in the crisis when protection becomes more expensive.

Bankruptcy does not work identically either. A company's assets can be sold and its operations closed. What does liquidating a sovereign city mean? Who maintains essential services, obligations to residents, judicial records, and control of force? If a higher authority must intervene, corporate sovereignty was not self-sufficient. If nobody intervenes, residents bear a risk managerial language can conceal.

Decentralising territory is not decentralising power

A thousand absolute local authorities do not become a free world merely by multiplying. Territory can be decentralised while power is completely concentrated within each parcel. If a resident cannot participate in rule-setting, lacks an independent arbiter, and has no bearable exit, the contract becomes the practical status of a subject. Feudalism does not cease to be a relevant analogy because the document is called terms and conditions.

Not every new-city project, voluntary community, or experimental jurisdiction is neoreactionary. The objection concerns a configuration in which infrastructure ownership becomes insufficiently limited political authority. Examining this conversion requires no attribution of a common ideology to every investor. The question is what owners can do to the people living within their systems, not how innovative those owners claim to be.

An experimental community could be legitimate if it preserved basic rights, independent arbitration, transparent obligations, and realistic exit. But insofar as these guarantees are protected by a wider constitutional order, the project has not transcended democracy's problems or the rule of law. It benefits from their partial solutions.

The illusion of government without politics lies in assuming that divergent interests disappear when the leader is called a chief executive. They do not disappear. They become decisions in which some people no longer have a voice. Managerial competence can be admirable without deciding who must bear a cost or who may be excluded from a community.

A billionaire receives no presumption of virtue denied to a politician. Nor does economic effectiveness demonstrate competence to determine what other people's lives should be. When the alternative to a captured state is a sovereign owner, capture has not been eliminated. It has been written into the founding charter. A genuine escape from domination must reduce discretionary power, not merely change its beneficiary and interface.

11. AI and the Manufacture of Dependence

Capacity for whom?

Artificial intelligence can reduce the cost of competence and increase the power of infrastructure owners. Both effects can occur simultaneously. A small organisation can do things previously beyond its reach while depending on a provider that controls access, price, data, and continuity. Democratising the use of a capability is not identical to democratising control over it.

Brynjolfsson, Li, and Raymond studied the introduction of a generative assistant in customer support. Their 2025 publication reports an average productivity increase of approximately 15%, with important differences among workers. This is evidence about complementarity and the redistribution of competence in a particular context, not proof that all professions will disappear or that workers receive all the gains (Brynjolfsson et al., 2025).

The ILO's 2025 report distinguishes task exposure to AI from the disappearance of jobs. That distinction is fundamental: a model's ability to perform part of an activity does not by itself establish how quickly an occupation is reorganised, what additional demand emerges, or which limits costs and responsibility impose (Gmyrek et al., 2025).

Three questions must be separated: what can the technology produce, who owns the means, and who can impose the terms of distribution? Productivity growth does not automatically answer the other two. We can become collectively richer and individually easier to exclude. We can receive extraordinary tools and lose control over the conditions of their use. That combination contains both AI's promise and its political danger.

When your labour is no longer needed

One scenario is more serious than unemployment: losing bargaining power grounded in a necessary contribution. As long as an activity depends on human labour, those performing it possess a resource they can offer, negotiate over, or withdraw. If many tasks could be performed without them, some of that power would diminish. Political rights, economic demand, and organisational capacities would not automatically disappear. But the relationship between capital owners and the rest of society could change in a way an income payment alone does not cancel.

The scenario does not declare people without jobs worthless. It distinguishes moral worth from bargaining power. A society can formally recognise everyone's dignity while allowing a very small group to decide infrastructure, access, and the collective agenda. If the majority owns no assets, cannot withdraw an indispensable contribution, and lacks independent organisations, a right to material support can coexist with very little capacity to influence the future.

Automating administration and some surveillance functions could intensify this asymmetry if it reduced the centre's dependence on human cooperation. This is a conditional extrapolation, not a demonstrated result concerning a future state. The design criterion must therefore be stated in advance: do not bind the provision of livelihoods, assessment of loyalty, and punishment of refusal to the same infrastructure. When these functions merge, comfort can become an instrument of submission without ceasing to be comfort.

A planner who knows more does not know everything

A defender of centralisation may argue that AI solves the old information problem: the centre can integrate data, simulate scenarios, and detect anomalies at a previously impossible scale. Some informational costs may plausibly fall. Declaring every conflict between centre and society solved is not plausible.

A better-informed planner does not automatically become more legitimate. It can rigorously optimise an imposed objective, exclude difficult-to-measure interests, and treat contestation as noise. Data may already reflect power relations, while those being evaluated learn to produce the desired indicator. AI can reduce parts of the information problem without eliminating conflict over ends or administrators' interest in preserving their positions. Assisted planning is not the abolition of politics.

Uniformity creates another risk. Apparently independent institutions using the same models, sources, and evaluation criteria may reproduce the same error. Ten software agents do not provide ten independent perspectives merely because they have different names. The diversity required for oversight must exist in data, methods, authority, and possibilities of challenge—not just in the interface.

Provenance, reproducible assessments, and verifiable decision records can assist oversight. Yet a perfectly recorded abuse remains an abuse if nobody can stop it. Auditability must not be sold as a substitute for rights of challenge, evaluator independence, and sanctioning power. Power can become more transparent and still harder to refuse if society loses material alternatives.

Four possible futures, without invented probabilities

The first scenario is concentrated rents. A few actors control indispensable infrastructure while everyone else purchases access. Productivity rises, but autonomy does not rise at the same pace. State-distributed income can partly compensate for lost wage bargaining power without altering ownership.

A second future is productive paternalism. Concentrated infrastructure finances extensive material protection, while citizens gradually lose control over the rules in exchange for service continuity. The first generations of administrators need not be abusive. The danger lies in the architecture available to successors: can identity, access to money, and permission to participate be turned into one admission system? If so, initial benevolence is an insufficient guarantee.

The third is productive polycentrism. Accessible models, portable data, open standards, and diversified infrastructure enable small organisations to perform complex tasks. The state remains necessary for some common goods and limits, but is not the sole provider of capacity. This scenario requires institutional work and investment. Publishing model weights alone does not produce it.

A fourth future is coercive fragmentation: technology lowers the cost of cooperation and the cost of some groups imposing harm on others. Local autonomy does not guarantee respect for neighbours, and distributing computing does not automatically distribute accountability. This is the reverse of decentralised utopia. It requires defence and arbitration precisely where the project hoped to reduce the centre.

The scenarios can combine. A world can be decentralised at the application layer, oligopolistic at the infrastructure layer, and centralised in the use of force. The number of agents or servers therefore does not adequately measure the distribution of power. What matters is which dependencies cannot be bypassed.

Verifiable technologies can support oversight: audits, proofs concerning operations, separated authorisations, and data-protection mechanisms. Cryptography nevertheless does not independently decide legitimate ownership, adjudicate conflicts, or stop those using force. A protocol needs a relationship with the world, and that relationship remains political.

AI can make additional autonomy possible without making it inevitable. The difference will appear in people's ability to retain data, change tools, own productive assets, and challenge decisions without material exclusion. A civilisation of exceptionally well-served users is not necessarily a civilisation of free people. The question is not only how much the system can do for you, but how much you can still do against it when it wrongs you.

12. Guaranteed Income—or a Guaranteed Leash?

A transfer is not a constitution

Universal basic income, as discussed here, is a periodic individual payment not conditional on work or a poverty assessment. AI progress does not make any particular income formula mandatory. Universal services, distributed ownership, social dividends, reduced working hours, or combinations can be imagined. The choice concerns power as well as accounting: who owns the assets, and who depends on a decision to continue payment?

Shorter paid working time, public services, taxation, ownership participation, and dividends from collectively held assets can be combined. Their differences matter. A transfer funded annually through a majority's goodwill may offer a different independence from a stable claim on a diversified fund. A universal public service may secure access better than cash in a blocked market, while also creating dependence on a single bureaucratic provider.

Society consumes housing, energy, food, care, and other goods—not money. Financing a transfer and producing what it purchases are distinct problems. Neither a promise to tax AI nor anticipated productivity gains removes questions of ownership, local scarcity, or resource conflict. A payment generous on paper can meet an inflexible supply and change prices before it changes autonomy.

Inflation cannot be invoked as an automatic verdict against every transfer either. Effects depend on financing, supply, unused capacity, and bottlenecks. But a system providing money without addressing monopolies and rigid supply may pass part of the benefit to owners of scarce resources. Distributing purchasing power is not always equivalent to distributing durable bargaining power.

What experiments show, without the advertising

Finland's 2017–2018 experiment provided a sample of 2,000 unemployed people with €560 per month. The official evaluation reported small employment effects and better perceived well-being in survey responses. Interpreting employment outcomes is complicated by a concurrent reform, while differing survey response rates limit conclusions about well-being. It was not universal income paid throughout an entire economy (Kela, 2020).

In the 31 December 2025 version of Vivalt and colleagues' study, 1,000 low-income individuals received $1,000 per month for three years, while 2,000 control-group

participants received $50. The authors estimated a 4.1-percentage-point reduction in labour-market participation and approximately one to two fewer working hours per week. Leisure accounted for the largest increase when leisure categories were combined, although individual time-use estimates carried uncertainty. This is a working paper, not definitive evidence about every form of basic income (Vivalt et al., 2025).

The findings justify neither the portrait of an inevitably lazy recipient nor the promise that release from economic pressure spontaneously produces entrepreneurs, researchers, and artists. The experiments cited do not support an automatic renaissance. Rest can be a legitimate use of income. Politically, however, we must ask separately whether people gain power over their lives or merely become better able to tolerate powerlessness.

Nor do limited experiments answer the question of a world where paid work becomes scarce for most people. Participants lived in work-centred societies, knew the experiments would end, and did not control the conditions of the whole economy. There is no direct observation here of a post-work civilisation. Any conclusion about its stability over centuries remains an extrapolation.

Does the citizen sustain the system—or does the system maintain the citizen?

Guaranteed income can finance refusal of abuse. It can also finance citizens' retreat from a world whose rules are set by others. The difference is not contained in the sum transferred. It depends on enforceable rights, alternative infrastructures, participation, and the inability to turn payment into a condition of obedience. An allowance for political neutralisation can look identical in the accounts to a measure of emancipation.

Several design criteria follow: enforceable entitlements that can be defended before an independent court, separation of payment administration from the assessment of opinions, data protection, and continuity during technical error. Not all require a central database. Nor does technical distribution eliminate legal responsibility. A system must be able to correct mistakes and identify the institution obliged to answer for them.

A further danger requires no explicit political condition: payment remains universal, but everyday life is enclosed among a few suppliers of housing, energy, health, and entertainment. Recipients receive money and return almost all of it to the same ownership structure. This is a rent-circulation scenario, not an inevitable consequence of basic income. It shows why checking freedom cannot stop at whether a transfer is unconditional.

A policy preserving income while destroying productive alternatives may purchase present peace with future dependency. A policy distributing ownership, access, and organisational power can turn the same abundance into autonomy. Asset distribution alone is insufficient if assets are subsequently reconcentrated or administered by an unaccountable caste. The question must be followed from the transfer to effective control, without stopping at the first favourable indicator.

Ownership matters as much as income. If people depend exclusively on transfers from productivity owned by others, the political relationship remains fragile. Asset participation, independently governed funds, cooperatives, and open public infrastructures can diversify sources of autonomy. Each nevertheless creates administrators and opportunities for capture. Calling a fund “everyone's” does not guarantee everyone's control over it.

Common contribution does not disappear because some tasks are automated. Care, institutional maintenance, scrutiny of power, and the obligation not to arbitrarily impose the costs of one's conduct on others remain. A post-work society may need more civic responsibility, not less. Treating every requirement of reciprocity as an offence against freedom would leave cooperation at the discretion of those willing to exploit it.

Guaranteed income should not be rejected because it can be captured. Its presentation as a complete solution should be rejected. Without distributed capacities and limits on administrators, it can become a leash that does not hurt until someone tries to move away. A free order is recognised not only by how it feeds citizens, but by what it allows them to refuse without starving them.

13. Well-Fed People Are Not Reconciled People

The morning when nobody needs you

Abundance's most troubling scenario need not be a shortage of money. It may be the disappearance of a sentence that organised life: someone needs me to turn up tomorrow. Work provides income, but can also provide rhythm, contact, obligations, recognition, and an account of personal usefulness. Sometimes it instead provides humiliation and exhaustion. Collapsing all these functions into one word prevents us from understanding what should be preserved and what could be removed.

Not everyone will become a cosmic explorer, artist, or researcher when wage pressure disappears. Presenting that transformation as the normal response to abundance projects the preferences of people who already imagine life in such terms. Some need stronger external structures, clear tasks, and predictable recognition. Others will seek intensity, competition, or power. None of these possibilities disappears by renaming free time “opportunity.”

Self-determination theory, summarised by Ryan and Deci, emphasises autonomy, competence, and relatedness as important dimensions of motivation and well-being. It is not a complete plan for organising a post-work economy. It offers a useful warning: material comfort is not the only variable, and passive satisfaction of desires is not identical to participating in a life experienced as one's own (Ryan and Deci, 2000).

Autonomy, competence, and relationships provide a framework for understanding motivation, not a formula producing meaning for everyone. Enjoyable activity and the feeling that one's presence matters are not identical. Someone can consume excellent experiences and feel socially useless; another can live modestly while occupying a role on which others depend. If AI changes the distribution of these roles, the political question extends beyond available leisure time (Ryan and Deci, 2000).

Boredom is not innocent—but neither is it destiny

Abundance cannot make everyone first, universally admired, or in command. Some goods are relational: their value depends on a position relative to others. Anderson and colleagues' review supports the broad importance of status motivation without reducing it to a universal desire for tyranny (C. Anderson et al., 2015). Eliminating material deprivation therefore does not logically eliminate comparative humiliation, competition for attention, or demands for recognition.

Pfattheicher and colleagues investigated links between boredom and sadistic aggression through observational studies and experiments. Their findings depend in part on available alternatives and differences between individuals; they do not describe a post-work population. They nevertheless make it unjustified to assume that boredom is politically innocent or that additional stimulation always takes a benign form (Pfattheicher et al., 2021).

The evidence does not form a simple law. In a student experiment, Lee, Drody, and Danckert did not find the anticipated general relationship between boredom proneness and the intention to harm; some patterns ran against an expectation of uniformly increased aggression. Such variation calls for caution in extrapolation, not removal of the question (Lee et al., 2025).

The severe political scenario does not require a sadistic majority. At scale, even an unquantified fraction attracted to controlling others can create serious problems if powerful tools and an audience are available. This is not an estimate of prevalence or a critical threshold. It is a robustness requirement: an order must withstand participants who seek not only well-being but the satisfaction of subordinating others.

Games, music, sexuality, sport, and virtual realities can fill time and possess genuine value. Added together, however, they do not constitute a constitution. Billions of entertainment libraries do not answer who matters in the shared world. A society can saturate consumption while leaving a hunger for status, risk, or domination untouched. Confusing these different needs is among the most naive promises of a utopia of comfort.

Preserving misery artificially to obtain discipline would be absurd. Assuming that the disappearance of misery produces discipline automatically would be equally naive. Economic pressure can organise life without making it good; removing it requires other structures of commitment, responsibility, and consequences. Offering activities is not enough. Some activities must matter to someone else and allow participants to answer for real outcomes.

Suitable institutions might include open research communities, care, reciprocal education, local governance, sport, and shared material projects. These are neither universal treatments nor occupations prescribed by a ministry of meaning. The criterion is stricter than keeping people busy: an activity must leave participants initiative, the possibility of failure, proportionate obligations, and power over a real part of the world. Simulated participation produces administrative therapy, not citizenship.

Will anything matter when AI does it better?

If an artificial intelligence composes more sophisticated music than an amateur, does the amateur lose every reason to play? Only if the activity's value lay exclusively in comparing its product with the best possible product. Much of human activity matters through relationships, process, learning, and expression. A child does not cease to matter to a parent because someone else can draw better.

Someone who loses a profession cannot have that loss cancelled by a recommendation to take up a hobby. Income, identity, rank, relationships, and daily evidence of usefulness may all have been lost. Some can be rebuilt; not all are interchangeable. A policy reducing that loss to individual emotional adaptation absolves the architect of change before investigating the distribution of costs.

There is a difference between authentic activity and an artificial simulation of importance. If AI tells every user they are an exceptional creator while nobody needs their work, a comfortable isolation can emerge. Not because virtual experience is necessarily false, but because the link between action and a shared world can become extremely thin. Unlimited affirmation is not the same as recognition from someone free to disagree.

Useless tasks should not be invented merely to preserve a fiction of human necessity. Human control over shared purposes, resources, and rules should be preserved. Even when a machine executes an operation better, the questions of who authorises it and who bears the result remain. Participating in those decisions can be real activity with real consequences, not a game in which AI politely lets people believe they have won.

A civilisation of adults, not an amusement park

“We govern; you enjoy life” is not a contract among equals when some reserve the power to redefine everyone else's benefits unilaterally. It may provide comfort, temporary stability, and even sincere consent. It does not guarantee freedom. A citizen turned permanent beneficiary is vulnerable both to an administrator's cruelty and to the habit of no longer deciding.

An apparently satisfied population can also lose the skills required for contestation. If organising one's life, verifying information, and acting collectively are outsourced entirely, autonomy can become a word for a convenient interface. This is a conceptual risk of dependency, not a claim that the process has already been completed.

Participation cannot be intensely demanding for every person at all times. But enough people and organisations must be able to inspect, challenge, and assume responsibilities without the centre's goodwill. A society of adults permits temporary withdrawal while preserving the possibility of return. A domesticated society supplies consumption and makes intervention in the real world increasingly difficult.

Neither art, games, sexuality, nor virtual reality is inherently a symptom of degradation. The problem begins with coercion, exploitation, dependency, and the elimination of the ability to choose something else. Prohibiting pleasure to preserve discipline would recreate the authoritarianism we claim to overcome. Ignoring the structures that turn pleasure into captivity would be the opposite naivety.

Benign abundance is not the abundance producing the most experiences, but the abundance that does not reduce people to managed consumers. There is a positive but demanding prospect here: technology can release time for real autonomy only if people retain the means to use that time against dependency. Without those means, a comfortable paradise risks becoming merely a more attractive form of political minority—a condition of permanent tutelage.

14. Virtues That Produce Their Opposites

Transparency, privacy, and the theatre of verification

We demand transparency to control power. We demand privacy to avoid being controlled by power. Making transparency a uniform obligation would render vulnerable people easier to monitor while allowing powerful organisations to use their data more effectively than they can. The response is not an equal amount of visibility for everyone, but a justified asymmetry: power must explain more, while individuals must be able to protect more.

Transparency can become theatre when it generates more documents than there is capacity for scrutiny. Power can publish immaculate procedures, abundant indicators, and endless explanations while leaving the distribution of decision-making hidden. Seeing something is not enough; people must be able to understand, verify, and produce consequences. An audit changing no incentives can become a certificate of respectability for a practice it accurately describes.

Auditing can itself become theatre. An organisation learns to produce documents satisfying evaluators without changing practice. Evaluators may be paid by those evaluated. An audit formally independent may depend economically on retaining its client. Scrutiny must therefore examine not only an activity but the market in scrutiny: who selects the auditor, who pays, who can challenge the conclusion, and what the auditor loses by being wrong.

AI can lower the cost of reading documents and the cost of manufacturing apparently impeccable documents. This does not make auditing useless. It requires evidence closer to real processes: action records, sampling, independent observations, and the right to confront an explanation with its effects. An elegant account does not establish that an institution operated as claimed.

Tolerance and defence against those who would abolish it

Tolerance meets its limit when it protects the organisation of those seeking to abolish the possibility of contradiction. Yet power can use precisely that explanation to label every opponent a threat. Choosing one side of the formula offers no moral refuge. A society that does not defend itself can be captured. A society granting its leader unlimited power to define defence can be captured through its own defence.

Opinion, organisation, and coercive action must be distinguished. Criticising a regime is not equivalent to intimidating opponents, organising violence, or eliminating

competition through abuse of office. Restrictions should address demonstrable conduct and risks, remain proportionate, and be open to challenge. This is a normative principle, not a description of any jurisdiction's law.

The V-Dem Democracy Report 2026, principally describing conditions through the end of 2025, identifies 44 countries undergoing autocratisation and 18 undergoing democratisation. Its indicators are methodological constructions, not metaphysical verdicts on societies. The findings support the existence of a serious contemporary risk, while also showing that the direction is not identical everywhere (V-Dem Institute, 2026).

Freedom providing means to destroy freedom is not a logical contradiction but a political possibility. V-Dem describes trends and indicators; it does not identify one universal cause of deterioration. The antinomy remains: rights and competition can bring actors to power who then close competition, while attempts to stop them can themselves authorise abuse. Defence must be tied to verifiable conduct, limited mandates, and independent oversight—not the supposed purity of our own camp (V-Dem Institute, 2026).

Safety that immobilises, innovation that exposes

Innovation requires permission to try things whose outcomes are not completely known. Safety requires that the costs of experimentation not be blindly imposed on others. Prohibiting every uncertainty favours existing technologies and organisations. Permitting every experiment may turn the public into non-consenting participants in tests conducted by those with capital.

A better rule would distinguish bounded, reversible experiments voluntarily undertaken by participants from experiments with extensive and hard-to-remedy effects. The more irreversible a possible consequence, the stronger its justification must be. Yet irreversibility belongs to inaction as well as action: delaying a technology can create unrecoverable costs. Precaution must be compared with alternatives, not an imaginary risk-free present.

In economics, the same tension appears between efficiency and resilience. Removing all reserves can lower current costs and increase vulnerability to shocks. Duplicating every capacity can be prohibitive. There is no universally optimal reserve; the consequences of failure, correlation of risks, and recovery time matter. The reasoning applies to institutions too: two bodies relying on the same data source and financier may not provide their promised redundancy.

Ecology, population, and absent generations

Prosperity can relieve deprivation and create means for environmental protection. It can also increase total consumption. Greater efficiency per unit does not guarantee lower aggregate consumption if the number of units grows enough. This is an arithmetic relationship, not a universal condemnation of technical progress. Efficiency, volume, and material effects must be tracked together.

Population cannot be discussed separately from consumption per person, technology, and distribution. The same number of people can exert different ecological pressures under different productive systems. A policy considering only births while ignoring consumption and infrastructure can confuse a cause with the easiest target to control.

For long-run stability, free reproductive choices, education, and real opportunities to plan a family are preferable to coercion over bodies. This is also a moral limit on this book's proposal. Claiming to save humanity by making reproduction a privilege granted by administrators returns us to the problem of those who classify human worth.

Future generations cannot vote today, and those claiming to represent them can project their own preferences onto them. The future should not therefore be ignored. Its protection should concentrate on preserving options: avoiding irreversible destruction, maintaining adaptive capacity, and enabling institutions to revise decisions as knowledge changes. We do not know what people will want a thousand years from now. We can try not to consume all their possibilities in advance.

Morality that buys impunity

Another inversion deserves attention: a powerful moral purpose can justify suspending oversight of those invoking it. Someone fighting for equality may consider questions about personal privileges illegitimate. A defender of tradition may claim a right to humiliate. Someone promising to save the planet may treat people affected by the project as moral obstacles. Abuse does not disprove the purpose. It disproves the claim that the purpose makes scrutiny of means unnecessary.

The harder a cause is to challenge morally, the more carefully its administrator should be scrutinised institutionally. This is a proposed normative rule, not a measured empirical relationship. It protects a cause against those treating it as property. When an ideal's representative treats personal criticism as an attack on goodness itself, we have returned to the manufacture of masters.

The same test must apply to this book. Refusing domination can be used to justify one's own domination; counterpower can become the name of a new oligarchy. No formula exempts itself through self-description. If our project demands powers we would not give an adversary, the antinomies have already caught us in their mechanism.

15. Counterpower, Not Goodwill

After the failure of the single principle

Libertarianism does not eliminate power by reducing the state; it must explain how private domination is limited. Socialism does not eliminate privilege by socialising ownership; it must explain who controls the administrator. Democratic liberalism does not preserve freedom merely through elections; it must explain how concentrated resources are prevented from draining participation of effect. Each principle encounters a power it makes possible and cannot constrain simply by repeating its promise.

These traditions contain variants and genuine attempts at self-correction. The book does not claim that every author ignores the problem. Its claim is different: neither property, equalisation, nor electoral consent alone supplies a sufficient mechanism of stability and non-domination. When these doctrines require additional institutions, they implicitly acknowledge a single principle's insufficiency. Mature discussion begins where the promise of self-sufficiency ends.

It would be too easy to conclude by proposing a “repairable order,” as though the phrase contained the workshop, spare parts, and right to intervene. Repairable for whom? With whose money? Against whose resistance? A society can possess every correction procedure and lack an independent actor capable of activating any of them. The answer is not declared repairability, but the material distribution of the power to impose correction.

Ostrom's work on polycentrism shows institutional possibilities beyond the simplistic choice between a single centre and an ungoverned market. It does not prove that every multiplication of centres resolves capture (Ostrom, 2010). Multiple administrators can form a cartel. Multiple procedures can depend on one financier. The number of organisations does not adequately measure their independence.

The capacity to say no

The capacity to say no requires minimum material security without being reducible to it. It also requires a usable alternative: another employer, provider, information source, independent arbiter, or representative organisation. If these routes exist formally but remain practically inaccessible, freedom is retained as a formula and withdrawn as an option. A politics of autonomy must track precisely that difference.

No actor should be able to close off income, housing, identity, communication, and access to contestation simultaneously. This is a proposed constitutional rule, not a description of the contemporary world. It requires separating essential dependencies and protecting channels that cannot be suspended to punish criticism. When all

functions are integrated for efficiency, the efficiency of future abuse must also be calculated.

A further condition is distributed ownership of productive capacities and infrastructures. Income transfers can address concentration's effects; access to assets can alter the power relationship. Possible instruments include competing enterprises, cooperatives, diversified funds with controllable governance, and common infrastructures. No single model should monopolise the entire system, because each develops its own interests in self-preservation.

Redundancy costs money. Independent institutions, alternative infrastructures, and reserve capacities consume resources a centralised arrangement would save. But saving those resources can make refusal impossible. Not every duplication should be preserved. We must distinguish redundancy providing autonomy from duplication sustaining a rent. The criterion is not how many centres exist, but whether one can survive another's opposition.

The controller also needs a controller

Counterpower is not another name for virtuous civil society. A union can be captured, a civic organisation can become a closed career structure, the press can serve its financier, and a local community can persecute dissent. The architecture must also constrain those tasked with constraining power. Otherwise, moral monopoly has merely moved from one office to another.

The difference between an unproductive spiral of controllers and a functional distribution of oversight is the possibility of outside intervention. No final incorruptible supervisor is required. What is required is that actors cannot jointly close every route through which they may be investigated, replaced, or challenged by competitors. How expensive this is varies across arrangements. An attractive constitutional diagram does not guarantee it.

The persistence-of-power model demands an adversarial test: assume that those losing through reform invest in neutralising it. Can they purchase an evaluator's funding, close a competitor's access, or influence the appointment of an arbiter? Acemoglu and Robinson explain theoretically why such compensation is plausible. An institutional proposal must show where it raises the price and makes the process observable (Acemoglu and Robinson, 2008).

Separating functions that can be corrupted together

The separation of powers matters only insofar as it separates the capacities to decide and resist. Evaluation, execution, financing, and sanction must not be departments of the same coalition under different names. Independence does not follow from an

organisational chart. Appointments, budgets, careers, infrastructure, and personal dependencies must be examined. Two institutions with different logos can constitute one centre of power.

An auditor who loses a contract for discovering too much is not robust oversight. A journalist unable to survive an important investigation economically has fragile freedom. Prosecutors, judges, and technical evaluators whose careers depend on those scrutinised face the same problem. These examples state assessment criteria, not indiscriminate accusations. Power is tested through the consequences of refusal, not the solemnity of a professional oath.

Limited mandates can reduce personalisation of power while encouraging short-termism. Professional continuity can preserve competence while solidifying a caste. A more plausible combination separates temporary political functions from stable professional capacities and subjects both to oversight. No magical rotation schedule simultaneously solves institutional memory and capture.

Regarding force, counterpower cannot mean permanent paralysis or every faction's right to impose its own order. Defence requires coherent command; freedom requires that command cannot extend its own mandate. Authorisation, resources, abuse control, and termination of exceptions must be distributed so that an emergency cannot become an unlimited certificate of sovereignty. There is no complete technical solution: that distribution must itself be defended politically.

The constitution as a testable hypothesis

A constitution should also be read as a set of hypotheses about power's behaviour. A particular limit is assumed to prevent a particular abuse. We must examine whether it prevents the abuse or moves it elsewhere, who bears the cost, and how actors adapt. Correct formulation is insufficient. A rule must remain usable against those powerful enough to circumvent it.

Useful measures include the time until abuse is detected, the duration and cost of a challenge, accessibility of alternatives, and recurrence after correction. Their distribution also matters: a procedure fast for the wealthy and impracticable for everyone else is not fast in a democratic sense. Indicators must nevertheless be confronted with qualitative investigation or they will become new targets for cosmetic compliance.

The hostile-successor test is simple: would we accept the same powers if our opponents exercised them tomorrow? A rule that seems safe only because we like its current holders is not a guarantee but a relationship of personal trust. Such trust may be necessary in life, but it is an insufficient foundation for institutions meant to outlive individuals.

A second test concerns a corrupt coalition. Assume that several oversight centres cooperate against the public. Which independent channels remain—press, courts, competition, external audit, authorities at another level, civic organisation? They cannot be declared independent by definition. Analysis must consider the cost of capturing them simultaneously and the signals such capture would produce.

The third test concerns the unprotected person. Can rights be used without connections, considerable money, or exceptional legal expertise? An institution working only for sophisticated users is a specialised instrument, not yet a general safeguard.

A fourth test concerns the exhausted majority. What happens when people lack the time, interest, or energy to monitor administration continually? A system requiring heroic vigilance every day is built for an imaginary citizen. It must allow delegation without losing the right to return and sustain oversight institutions that do not require mobilising the entire population for every abuse.

The fifth test concerns a convenient crisis. Can leaders prolong the emergency that enlarges their powers? Can another actor end the exception without its beneficiary's consent? If not, the mechanism already contains a route to capture. This does not establish that it will be used. It obliges the designer to explain why it remains open.

The limit of the irreversible

Not every error can be repaired. A lost life, destroyed community, or permanently damaged environment is not an earlier version that can simply be restored. Repairability therefore requires complementary limits on irreversible harm. As technical power grows, preventing a single actor from causing such harm without constraints and verification becomes more important.

This prudence must not become a general prohibition on the future. An order blocking every transformation can perpetuate avoidable suffering. It must compare action's risks with inaction's risks, test at limited scale where possible, and preserve alternatives. Under deep uncertainty, robustness across several futures may matter more than maximum performance within one convenient scenario.

No formula making domination impossible is offered here. A more demanding design criterion is offered than declared good governance: make it difficult to become indispensable, difficult to buy every route of challenge, and possible to lose power without collapsing society. A freer order does not rely on the absence of dangerous people. It limits their ability to turn their ambitions into everyone else's destiny.

16. How to Build the Power to Refuse

Do not dismantle before you can replace

Radical projects tend to describe the future order generously and the transition superficially. Yet the transition may concentrate more power than the regime it claims to supersede. To build a world without domination, exceptional authority is demanded; to defend the experiment, opposition is postponed; to complete the transformation, the exception is prolonged. Not every initiator needs to have been cynical. A badly designed route can select for cynicism along the way.

Reducing dependencies may require radical reforms, not merely polite adjustments. A monopoly may need to be opened or divided; essential infrastructure may require access rules; a function may have to be removed from the hands of those who profit from controlling it. Radicalism is measured not by the volume of the declaration but by a change in the balance of power. Each measure must nevertheless specify what capacity it creates in place of the capacity it restricts, and how it prevents the emergence of a new administrative monopoly.

Destroying an institution does not redistribute its power to citizens. That power may pass to the best-organised private actor, an informal network, or the group willing to use intimidation. The transition must be analysed as part of the design, not as an impure interval after which the utopia will suddenly become coherent. Every new authority needs a procedure for refusal from the beginning; a promise to accept scrutiny after completing the transformation is insufficient.

In AI, suitable initial projects are those whose scope can be bounded: access to public information, administrative assistance, the checking of procedures, and reusable tools for small organisations. Systems that decide liberty, livelihoods, or access to rights demand far greater caution. An experiment does not become legitimate merely by carrying an innovation label.

An institutional pilot must be able to fail honourably

Imagine a federation of municipalities building shared AI tools for administrative services. The hypothesis is that sharing reduces costs while preserving local control and the ability to change suppliers. Testing that hypothesis seriously requires more than counting users or documents produced.

The comparison must include total cost, error frequency, complaint-resolution time, access for people with limited digital skills, and the availability of an alternative service. Personal data should not be published to demonstrate transparency. Methods,

aggregate results, relevant incidents, and audit procedures can be published while protecting those affected.

Before expansion, departure must also be tested: can a municipality move its data and service to another supplier? Can it operate temporarily without the shared system? If not, the project has created a new dependency, even if its first version works well. An exit test is more informative than an abstract contractual promise of portability.

The pilot should also be tested against hostile leadership. Suppose a new administrator wants to make changing suppliers impossible, delay inconvenient complaints, and present the system's performance favourably. We do not ask anyone to simulate actual abuses against citizens; we examine procedures and dependencies through an assessment exercise. Who holds the keys, who can stop an integration, and who can keep the service running? If the answer is the same team in every case, control has not been distributed.

It must also be established whether an alternative exists outside the documentation. A data export that no other organisation can use is not operational portability. A contract permitting departure at a ruinous price does not produce independence. An audit that may be published only with the audited party's consent is not counterpower. These tests are less spectacular than the promise of a smart city and far more relevant to the freedom of its inhabitants.

A pilot needs public stopping criteria and responsibility for harm. Otherwise, its promoters will redefine success after seeing the result. Especially when a team's or a leader's reputation depends on an experiment, someone must be able to say that the hypothesis failed without being treated as an enemy of progress.

A pilot does not establish a complete political order. It does, however, demonstrate a transferable discipline: do not accept declared autonomy without a test of refusal, transparency without a test of consequences, or plurality without a test of independence. The same standard can be applied to a cooperative, a public administration, or a private platform. The organisation's name does not determine the outcome of the test.

Who will defend the rules when they become inconvenient?

Rules need defenders with resources, not merely people who endorse them in surveys. A coalition for freedom must be able to survive electoral defeat, an economic boycott, and hostility from part of the administration without disappearing. That capacity does not arise from abstract moral agreement. It is built through organisations, diversified funding, competence, and benefits distributed widely enough to give people something real to defend.

Transition creates real opponents. Some lose rents; others lose jobs, security, and status without having abused anyone. Treating both categories identically is unjust and strategically foolish. Legitimate costs require protection and alternatives; privilege does not require preservation merely because its beneficiary regards it as an acquired entitlement. The distribution of these costs is part of the substance of reform, not a public-relations task.

Winners do not accept limits merely because those limits have been explained pleasantly. They may accept them because they know they could lose tomorrow, because others can block an abuse, or because a limited order offers them more than risky domination. If they believe they can lock everything down indefinitely, the argument from reciprocity weakens. Counterpower is therefore a material condition of civility, not its opposite. Reasonable negotiation also depends on the impossibility of unlimited imposition.

We cannot promise the end of political fragility. We can reject manufactured fragility: dependence on a single leader, a single supplier, a single source of truth, and a single exclusion switch. Alternatives do not eliminate conflict, but they can prevent every disagreement from becoming a struggle for survival. Stability deserves defence when it permits conflict without submission, not when it conceals conflict beneath the silence of those who cannot afford to speak.

Institutions that acknowledge their capacity for error are not enough. We need institutions that others can stop when they refuse to acknowledge it. The difference between those two propositions is the difference between professed wisdom and protected freedom. The future must not be left to whoever promises most persuasively to take care of us.

Epilogue. The Future Cannot Be Delegated

No project can grant itself exemption from scrutiny. Those promising equality must be asked what privileges their administrators produce. Those promising freedom must be asked what dependencies their arrangements of property permit. Those promising order must be asked who can stop a command. An ideal is not evidence that the mechanism serves it.

Nor is “there are no solutions” an adequate verdict. It confuses the absence of a total guarantee with the absence of differences we can make. An institution you can refuse is different from one that owns your existence. That difference does not become trivial because it fails to resolve history.

AI does not absolve us of politics. Guaranteed income does not absolve us of property. Local community does not absolve us of force. Education does not absolve us of the selection of castes. Rights do not absolve us of reproducing the conditions in which they can be exercised. Every solution can produce an intermediary that declares its function indispensable and then demands to be left alone.

Antinomies require us not to confuse the success of a means with the achievement of an end. If we have eliminated hunger, who controls the food? If we have distributed information, who distributes attention? If we have automated work, who controls productive capacity? If we have multiplied communities, who protects those who no longer wish to belong?

There is a positive possibility: technology can reduce the cost of autonomy, and institutions can make challenge less ruinous. We can build capacities that do not require everyone to seek the same centre's permission. This is not the certainty of a utopia. It is a concrete direction that can be tested and is worth defending.

We manufacture our own masters when we confuse care with the right to rule, competence with the right to escape accountability, and comfort with freedom. We stop doing so not when we discover the perfect ruler, but when we build the means through which no one can become a master without encountering organised, legitimate resistance capable of enduring.

We do not need the promise that power will become good. We need the power to say no to it.

Appendix A. What We Can Support—and Where Hypothesis Begins

The claims below summarise the argument and identify the kind of support each has. A thesis can be firm without being universal. A theoretical mechanism identifies possibilities and conditions; an empirical study examines a bounded domain; a norm states what we choose to protect. None of these categories should substitute for another.

Equalisation can produce administrative privilege

Status: a historically supported mechanism in systems with concentrated power, not a law governing every redistribution. Analysis must include access, discretion, and immunity, not merely income. The relevant test is whether reduced monetary inequality coincides with the distribution or concentration of the capacity to make decisions over others. Classical socialism and public services in a democracy cannot be treated as the same intervention (Kornai, 1992).

Markets can be captured by their winners

Bounded empirical studies and theoretical models support a distinction between formal rights and effective influence. Gilens and Page analyse decisions in the United States; Acemoglu and Robinson model the persistence of power through responses that offset institutional change. The book's general conclusion is a mechanism-based interpretation, not a universal capture rate (Gilens and Page, 2014; Acemoglu and Robinson, 2008).

Noise can be used strategically

Status: a mechanism documented in particular communication operations. Generalisation to the entire public sphere requires further evidence. Intentional coordination, commercial incentives, and ordinary competition for attention must be distinguished. Evidence about one operation cannot automatically be transferred to another platform or country (King et al., 2017).

Algorithms can change political attitudes

Status: causal effects that depend on the platform, intervention, sample, and period. Mixed results rule out both universal exoneration and a universal explanation through algorithms. A better research programme would measure effects over different

durations, changes in networks of relationships, and persistence after an intervention ends (Guess et al., 2023; Gauthier et al., 2026).

Education does not guarantee intellectual independence

An economic model explains conformity to a superior's opinion when evaluation rewards agreement. The extension to intellectual caste, pseudo-erudition, and organisational selection is argued analytically, but is not measured here in an original comparative study (Prendergast, 1993).

Competition among elites can amplify instability

Status: a contestable explanatory and predictive programme, not an inevitable law. The positions being sought, the aspirants, and the outcomes counted as instability must be defined in advance. Testing beyond the cases used to construct a model is more informative than retrospectively reinterpreting every crisis. More education is not, by definition, harmful overproduction (Turchin and Korotayev, 2020).

Resentment has material causes and status-related causes

Status: several mechanisms supported in different contexts; their relative weights are not universal. Methodological disputes over American voting and studies of trade shocks demonstrate the need to compare explanations. A social class cannot be treated as a uniform psychological character (Mutz, 2018; Morgan, 2018; Autor et al., 2020).

Fertility and cognitive ability have no simple universal relationship

The cited literature shows context-dependent relationships between educational or cognitive indicators and fertility. The model of differential investment in children identifies a mechanism of human-capital accumulation; it does not demonstrate the biological inferiority of social categories (Kong et al., 2017; Kolk and Barclay, 2019; de la Croix and Doepke, 2003).

Genetics does not establish an individual's civic destiny

Polygenic scores and heritability do not determine a child's civic destiny or authorise automatic inferences across groups. The transmission of norms is treated separately as a cultural process, with outcomes dependent on socialisation and environment. The risk of asymmetric reproduction of liberal and anti-liberal norms remains a hypothesis to test in specific contexts (Okbay et al., 2022; Bisin and Verdier, 2001).

Environment can change cognitive performance

The cited studies support effects of education and environment on cognitive performance; they do not demonstrate unlimited plasticity or the automatic compensation of every disadvantage. The book's political conclusion is that the reproduction of capacities must be evaluated materially, not assumed to arise spontaneously from declared rights (Ritchie and Tucker-Drob, 2018; Bratsberg and Rogeberg, 2018).

China's development does not establish the general superiority of autocracy

Status: the economic outcome is documented; attributing it exclusively to the political regime is not established. Reforms, administrative capacity, markets, the international context, and human costs must be compared. Performance-based promotion can coexist with patronage networks (World Bank and DRC, 2022; Jia et al., 2015).

Decentralisation does not eliminate capture or coercion

Status: a plausible mechanism and conditional institutional findings. Both control over the centre and protection for local dissenters must be measured. Communities can manage common resources, but defence, infrastructure, and arbitration across local boundaries remain distinct problems (Ostrom, 2010; Bardhan and Mookherjee, 2000).

Exit can discipline a jurisdiction, but cannot replace every right

Status: a normative and mechanism-based argument. The test requires actual relocation costs, available alternatives, and the treatment of people who are not profitable. The formal existence of another territory is insufficient. Neocameralist texts are objects of doctrinal analysis, not experimental findings (Moldbug, 2008; Land, 2012).

AI does not determine the distribution of power by itself

There is bounded evidence of productivity effects and analysis of occupational exposure. Lost bargaining power, automated paternalism, and emancipatory decentralisation are conditional scenarios, not demonstrated outcomes at the scale of a post-work economy (Brynjolfsson et al., 2025; Gmyrek et al., 2025).

Guaranteed income demonstrates neither universal idleness nor universal renaissance

Status: experimental findings limited to the programmes studied. Effects on work, well-being, and time use differ; generalisation to an entire economy or a post-work world remains uncertain. Duration, eligibility, financing, and institutional context are part of the result (Kela, 2020; Vivalt et al., 2025).

Abundance guarantees neither meaning nor generalised aggression

There are findings about status, motivation, and contextual relationships between boredom and aggression, including a study with results that do not uniformly support the hypothesis of generally increased aggression. We do not have a demonstration that abundance would produce generalised sadism; we have reasons not to assume automatic social peace (C. Anderson et al., 2015; Ryan and Deci, 2000; Pfattheicher et al., 2021; Lee et al., 2025).

No final resolution of the antinomies has been demonstrated

No work cited here establishes that every regime must collapse or that a particular architecture will remain stable indefinitely. The argument concerns identifiable mechanisms of self-degradation and the need to reproduce the conditions of freedom, not a theorem of fatality.

Counterpower is not a proven constitution

The separation of dependencies, material autonomy, distributed capacities, and adversarial tests are normative and design proposals. Their combination is not empirically validated here as a complete solution. Their central proposition is that correction possible only with the consent of the party being corrected is not sufficient control.

Ownership of information and access to attention

The comparative study of media ownership provides a historical empirical basis. The mechanism of editorial selection through resources and the hypothesis of domination through the distribution of attention are analytical extensions. We assert neither a single command centre for the press nor equivalence between public and private ownership (Djankov et al., 2003).

Appendix B. Limits of the Evidence and the Argument

This book is not a systematic review, a meta-analysis, or an exhaustive history of doctrines. Empirical findings, models, historical analyses, and doctrinal texts perform different functions. Citing a doctrine identifies what it proposes; it does not establish that it would work.

The book presents no original data or validated simulations. The experience of communism that motivates the questions is not a representative sample. The scenarios are thought experiments. Extending a mechanism beyond the study cited is the book's argument, not a finding attributed to that source.

The first substantial limitation is uneven geographical coverage. Some research on platforms, mobility, and populism concerns the United States, while some findings about fertility and cognition come from Nordic countries. Transfer to other contexts requires testing. The book does not claim that the same mechanisms have the same intensity everywhere.

The second limitation is the difficulty of comparing regimes. War, resources, institutional legacies, and international position may simultaneously affect forms of government and outcomes. Causal studies reduce some ambiguities; they do not eliminate every uncertainty. Autocracies and democracies should not be compared only through the cases most convenient to a thesis.

AI scenarios are not assigned numerical probabilities without a calibrated model. Testing them requires time horizons and indicators: infrastructure concentration, the cost of alternatives, participation in ownership, and the use of AI in coercive functions. The plausibility of a mechanism does not establish how often its outcome will occur.

Stronger testing would compare institutions and cohorts, track the distribution of real capacity to challenge power, and examine counterexamples: reforms that redistribute power durably, communities that protect dissent, and contexts in which the transmission of liberal norms strengthens. The thesis is not defended by redefining every success as a hidden failure. It must be able to lose against findings showing that mechanisms of degradation are durably counteracted.

The bibliography is retained from the revised manuscript and includes publications dated through 2026. Version-sensitive sources are identified where relevant. The period observed by a report must not be confused with its publication date or the date on which it was read. This English edition is dated 13 September 2026; it does not claim an exhaustive new literature search.

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